

# Free to Practice, Free from Terror: Freedom of Religion and Religious Terrorism

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## Abstract

What happens to religious terrorist organizations when states guarantee widespread religious freedoms? Prior research has traced the roots of religious terrorism to relative deprivation and religious favoritism, yet the role of broad religious freedoms has received little attention. I argue that religious terrorist groups decline where countries protect such freedoms. Guaranteeing the right to practice one's faith, I contend, equips states to resist religious terrorism through two mechanisms: it defuses the grievances that drive marginalized minorities toward violence, and, by extending equal treatment before the law, it constrains dominant religious groups from repressing minorities with impunity. Rather than a mere absence of repression, I treat religious freedom as a positive institutional arrangement that limits the state's reach into the religious sphere. Drawing on a range of cross-national data sources and estimation strategies, including models that exploit within-country changes in religious freedom over time, I assess how these protections shape the presence and behavior of religious terrorist organizations. The findings indicate that states with widespread religious freedoms host fewer such organizations than states with severe restrictions, and that these groups, where present, carry out fewer domestic attacks. The study reframes religious freedom as a stabilizing institution that affords states a comparative advantage against religious terrorism.

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<sup>†</sup>Data for this study is available upon request.

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# 1 Introduction

What causes the emergence of religious terrorist organizations? Which countries are targeted the most and why? These questions have been central to the study of terrorism, particularly in the aftermath of the devastating 9/11 attacks (Phillips 2023). In response to the escalating number of incidents and the rising toll of casualties, researchers and practitioners have undertaken various efforts to elucidate the underlying causes and motivations of religious violence.

Existing literature shows a robust relationship between religious discrimination and armed conflicts (Akbaba and Taydas 2011; Basedau et al. 2017; Basedau and Schaefer-Kehnert 2019; Muchlinski 2014, 2019; Saiya et al. 2024; Suntay 2025). Studies find that particular religious discrimination policies such as burqa bans (Saiya and Manchanda 2020) and blasphemy laws (Hassner 2011; Saiya 2017; Eskildsen and Bjørnskov 2025) can increase the occurrence of religious violence. Others demonstrate that governments' control over religious institutions (P. S. Henne 2019) and low-regulation over religious liberties (Saiya and Scime 2015) can be effective to curb religious terrorism.

Related studies also focus on the unique characteristics violent religious groups have. While some examine their distinct origins (Gunning and Jackson 2011; Satana et al. 2013), others investigate the motivations behind them (Rapoport 1983; Ranstorp 1996; Morgan 2004; Sedgwick 2004). Research shows that religious terrorist groups do not exhibit substantial differences in their discriminate use of violence or lethality (Asal et al. 2008; Masters 2008; Pape 2003; Piazza 2009; Robison et al. 2006). However, they are less likely to achieve their goals or integrate into political processes, while they tend to persist longer (Gaibullov et al. 2020). Nevertheless, what might deter these groups has received limited scholarly attention.

I aim to fill this gap in the literature. I argue that countries with broad freedom of religion have a comparative advantage against religious terrorist groups. States protecting their citizens' right to practice their faith through law, I contend, are more resilient to religious terrorism, particularly through two mechanisms. First, by securing the freedom to worship, such legal guarantees reduce the practice-based grievances that religious groups might otherwise mobilize into violence. Second, legal protections for religious practice shield religious minorities from repression, whether at the hands of the government/state bureaucracy or of dominant religious groups. I suggest that where the religious freedoms are common, then, religious terrorism should occur less.

Figure 1 plots the annual number of active terrorist organizations by type, illustrating the growing prominence of religious groups relative to others. The figure shows that religious terrorist groups have come to rival nationalist ones in salience, whereas left-wing and right-wing groups maintain a steady presence. Furthermore, these groups have nearly

doubled in number over the past two decades, underscoring the need to understand what drives their emergence and how they might be countered more effectively.

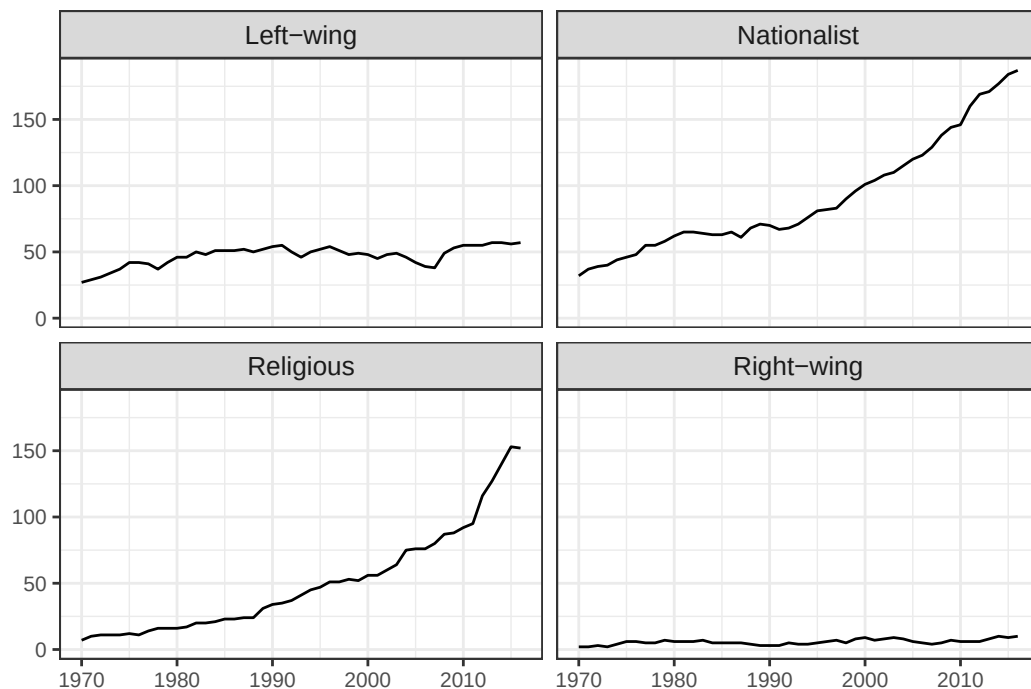


Figure 1: ANNUAL NUMBER OF TERRORIST GROUPS (1970-2016). Source: the Extended Data on Terrorist Groups (EDTG)

This study contributes to the literature in three respects. First, existing scholarship overwhelmingly attributes religious terrorism to persecution (Grim and Finke 2011) and restrictions (Saiya 2018). The handful of studies that engage freedom directly either do not test the purported relationship empirically (Saiya 2015, 2021) or, where they do test, they are either specific to one religion (Saiya 2025) or have limited temporal scope (Saiya and Scime 2015), leaving the underlying institutional logic and causal mechanisms under-theorized. I instead theorize religious freedoms as positive institutional arrangements. Re-viewing the main theories of religious violence, I offer an institutional account on how religious freedoms can afford states a strategic advantage against religious terrorist groups and thus assist them to prevent religious terrorism.

Second, I specify the mechanisms through which this advantage operates. By circumscribing the state's reach into the religious sphere and guaranteeing equality before the law, religious freedoms can attenuate the grievances driving marginalized minorities toward religious terrorism. By the same token, equal protection can dismantle the impunity that emboldens dominant majority groups to resort to terrorism, often in a majoritarian or vigilante form, to extract further concessions from the state.

Third, beyond these theoretical contributions, I test my hypotheses using multiple measures of religious terrorism. Because powerful groups can coerce without attacking and attack data may carry substantial reporting error, I complement standard attack counts with an actor-centered measure: the number of active religious terrorist organizations per country-year. I believe these measures together provide a more comprehensive assessment of the relationship between religious freedom and religious terrorism.

My results show that states with widespread religious freedoms host fewer religious terrorist organizations than do countries with severe restrictions on religious practice. Aligning with my theoretical framework, I also find that religious terrorist groups conduct fewer domestic attacks in countries with broad religious freedoms than their counterparts in states with restrictive policies.

In the following section, I first review the existing literature on religious terrorism. I then elaborate my theory and derive a set of testable hypotheses. The following section evaluates these hypotheses using several estimation strategies. I conclude by summarizing the study's key findings and outlining avenues for future research.

## 2 Literature Review

Religious terrorism emerged as a distinct type following several pivotal events in 1979, mainly the Soviet invasion of Afghanistan and the Iranian Islamic Revolution (Rapoport 2017a). Identified as the “fourth wave” of terrorism following the anarchist, anti-colonial, and new-left (Rapoport 2017b), this “new” terrorism gained heightened attention, particularly after the 9/11 attacks (Phillips 2023; Silke 2008). Early research primarily focused on understanding its nature. Foundational studies explored its various aspects, including the distinct motivations of religious terrorist groups (Rapoport 1983; Ranstorp 1996; Morgan 2004; Sedgwick 2004), their organizational structures (Byman 2003), the specific methods they adopt (Hoffman 2006), their members' personal characteristics (Sageman 2004; Schbley 2003; Stern 2003), and their attacks' broader implications (Hoffman 1995; Moghadam 2009).

Amid discussions on how this new form of terrorism differs from others (Crenshaw 2008; Duyvesteyn 2004; Fine 2008; Gunning and Jackson 2011; Spencer 2006; Tucker 2001), empirical research has revealed that religious terrorist groups do not vary significantly in their indiscriminate use of violence and level of lethality (Asal et al. 2008; Masters 2008; Pape 2003; Piazza 2009; Robison et al. 2006). Furthermore, studies indicate that these groups engage in rational decision-making and exhibit pragmatic behavior, challenging earlier assumptions about their purely transcendent or utopian goals (Berman and Laitin 2008; Nemeth 2017). Nevertheless, the role of religion remains a defining charac-

teristic that sets these groups apart from other types of terrorist organizations (Weinberg et al. 2004; Kurtulus 2011; Gregg 2014; P. Henne 2019).

In that regard, one major area of research on religious terrorism focuses on its root causes. Some scholars suggest that a lack of religious diversity is a contributing factor (Feldman and Ruffle 2008), while others highlight the roles of globalization (Cronin 2003), modernization (Robison et al. 2006), and specific policies like blasphemy laws (Saiya 2017) and burqa bans (Saiya and Manchanda 2020). Additionally, a broader body of literature on religion and violence highlights how grievances and discrimination contribute to the rise of religious violence (Basedau et al. 2011; Fox 2000, 1999). This perspective argues that deprivation leads to grievances, which can escalate into violent actions. Consequently, religious minorities who are marginalized by the majority may resort to violence, including terrorism, to demand political change.

The “weapon of the weak” argument originates in Gurr’s *Why Men Rebel* (2015). Gurr posits that individuals feel relative deprivation when their “value capabilities”, the lifestyle they believe they can attain, fall short of their “value expectations,” the lifestyle they feel entitled to. This gap breeds discontent and, in turn, forceful action. Crucially, the resulting violence is not random but is directed at those blamed for the grievance. Studies applying relative deprivation theory to religious terrorism show how restrictions on religious freedoms (Saiya 2025), state repression of religious institutions (P. S. Henne 2019), the absence of religious liberties (Saiya and Scime 2015; Saiya 2015), and faith-based marginalization (Saiya 2019) can foster conditions conducive to religious terrorist activity.

By contrast, recent scholarship holds that religious terrorism can also serve as a “weapon of the strong”. This approach suggests that state favoritism toward the religious majority groups may enable them to use violence to consolidate their existing privileges and marginalize minorities (Henne et al. 2020). Three mechanisms are proposed. Through *outbidding*, majority groups might deem existing favoritism insufficient and turn to terrorism to extract further concessions (Toft 2007, 2013). Under a *climate of impunity*, they may read their privileged status as licensing harassment and violence (Uddin 2011; Thames 2014; Saiya 2017). And anticipating *no judicial accountability*, they might face even weaker deterrents against using terrorism as a means (Bauman and Leech 2012).

Although the existing literature offers varied perspectives on the motivations behind religious terrorism, I argue that it has three main weaknesses. First, much of it explains these motivations through the strategic choices of religious terrorist groups or extremist individuals. Some recent work does examine broader structural factors, such as religious restrictions (Saiya 2019) and discrimination (Saiya et al. 2024), but much of it generalizes poorly, with scope conditions confined to Muslim-majority countries (Saiya 2017) or Western Europe (Saiya and Manchanda 2020) and often a limited temporal window (Saiya and Scime 2015). A more comprehensive, cross-national analysis is therefore needed to better

understand the dynamics of religious terrorism.

Furthermore, those studies emphasizing broader structural drivers of religious terrorism either overlook religious freedoms or reduce it to the absence of repression. This conception, I argue, is unduly narrow. Rather than treating religious freedom as the simple absence of repression, I theorize it as a positive institutional arrangement, one that affords states a strategic advantage against religious terrorist groups.

Finally, existing studies largely test their hypotheses using either the frequency of attacks (attacks per year) or their impact (resulting casualties)<sup>1</sup>. Relying on these measures alone, I contend, can mislead. Groups that are both active and powerful may coerce populations without attacking at all, and casualty counts may be biased by uneven reporting quality. By focusing solely on attacks or fatalities, then, studies risk overlooking the motivations underlying violent groups.

To gain a more comprehensive understanding, I adopt alternative indicators that are more actor-oriented and therefore can enable us to better capture the underlying causes of religious terrorism. Specifically, I use the number of terrorist groups per country-year as an alternative metric, complementing attack-based measures. Since these groups are the primary agents of terrorist violence, examining where they concentrate offers an effective way to assess my theoretical models. Accordingly, the next section develops my theoretical framework and hypotheses in detail.

### 3 Theory

My argument builds on recent scholarship showing that restrictions on religious freedom (Saiya 2015), state repression (P. S. Henne 2019), and the absence of religious favoritism (Saiya 2019) cause fertile grounds for religious terrorist organizations to gain power. Departing from this work, I foreground the converse logic: religious freedom instead affords states a distinct advantage in countering such organizations<sup>2</sup>. Conceding that restrictions may motivate violence, I contend that states with widespread religious freedoms are comparatively better placed to contain religious terrorism.

To develop this argument, I theorize my framework around two established accounts of religious violence, the weapon of the weak and weapon of the strong, and examine how

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<sup>1</sup>A certain number of studies uses terrorist groups as their unit of analysis. Those studies examine group formation (Phillips 2014), group survival (Young and Dugan 2014), the effects of competition with other groups (Nemeth 2014), state support (Carter 2012), and bargaining with states (Bapat 2006). Nevertheless, their one notable limitation is their restricted scope of group coverage either temporally or spatially.

<sup>2</sup>In a related study, Saiya and Scime (2015) examine the relationship between religious freedom and religious terrorism, though their analysis is confined to the 2001–2009 period. Grim and Finke (2011) likewise connect religious freedom to religious violence, but their focus is the broader phenomenon of violent religious persecution and conflict rather than terrorism as such.

religious freedom can defuse the core motivations each identifies. Although both have drawn substantial criticism<sup>3</sup>, I focus on them because they offer the most general explanations of why religious groups turn to terrorism, rather than isolating discrete factors that drive violence in particular cases. In the next section, I review each theory in turn and show how religious freedoms systematically mitigate the conditions it deems conducive to violence, thereby helping states address the root causes of religious terrorism and strengthen their resilience against it.

### 3.1 Theories of Religious Violence

Starting with the *weapon of the weak* framework, it holds that the principal driver of religious terrorist groups is state repression and the absence of religious freedoms (P. S. Henne 2019). When states ban particular freedoms and bar groups from practicing their faith, individuals feel deprived of their rights, and the repressed may turn to violence against those responsible for their oppression. As Gurr puts it, “An angered person is not likely to strike out at any object in his environment, but only at the targets he thinks are responsible” (2015, 34).

Nevertheless, this theory does not predict that all deprivation ends in violence. Depending on its intensity and other factors, such as ethnic tensions, deprivation can produce violent or non-violent outcomes (Basedau et al. 2017). Religious restrictions are thus a necessary but not a sufficient cause. They must be present for violence to occur, but their presence does not guarantee it.

By contrast, a second and more recent theory, the *weapon of the strong* framework, focuses on how state support for dominant groups incentivizes their violence. When governments favor certain religious groups, this can encourage them to use terrorism to discriminate against minorities (Henne et al. 2020). On this view, religious terrorism need not arise from grievances. It may instead stem from the state-backed empowerment of dominant groups deploying violence to preserve or extend their privileged position over minorities. The theory points to three mechanisms. First, majority groups may deem existing favoritism insufficient and resort to terrorism to demand further concessions. Furthermore, operating amid impunity, they may justify harassment and violence as legitimate. Finally, the perceived absence of judicial accountability lowers the costs of violence for them, encouraging its strategic use.

As each theoretical framework identifies different causes of religious terrorism, they also suggest different objectives that terrorist groups might pursue through violence. In

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<sup>3</sup>For instance, some studies pointed out methodological issues with the *weapon of the weak* theory (Hug 2003; Birnir et al. 2018). Others also failed to identify findings corroborating the theory’s implications (Collier and Hoeffler 2004).

other words, the underlying motivations identified by these theories fundamentally shape the distinct goals that groups pursue when employing terrorism.

According to the weapon of the weak argument, repressed groups most often use violence to reclaim lost freedoms. When states strip religious groups of their rights, these groups may mobilize and turn to terrorism as a tool to restore them and achieve political or social objectives. Rallying around principles and rights they see as unjustly denied, they may attack civilian or military targets. By demonstrating their capacity for retaliation and projecting strength against repression, these groups might aim to instill fear in broader populations and ultimately secure the restoration of their rights.

A second and related objective is enhancing bargaining power. Rather than reclaiming lost freedoms, violence may serve to improve repressed groups' position at the bargaining table. By inflicting harm and exposing the vulnerabilities of dominant groups, subjugated groups strengthen their leverage and extract greater concessions.

Under the weapon of the strong framework, motivations differ. Backed by state support, favored groups may use terrorism for two purposes: to protect their status in the existing social hierarchy or to secure additional privileges from the state. In the first case, because repressed groups may gain power over time, favored groups resort to violence to preserve their privileged position rather than to reclaim lost freedoms. In the second, under institutions governed by *rule by law* rather than *rule of law*, they can leverage violence to expand their advantages. Thus, terrorism serves not only to maintain their privileged position but to strengthen it further.

### **3.2 Freedom of Religion and Religious Terrorism**

Given the links between grievances, favoritism, and terrorism, I now turn to my argument on why states with widespread freedom of religion are markedly more resilient against religious terrorist organizations. I particularly focus on the political and legal arrangements through which religious freedoms can address the underlying causes of religious violence and counter the objectives that the two theories identify. By undermining the very foundations on which such groups operate, I argue that religious freedoms can make countries with stronger religious freedoms more resilient against them.

First, I posit that widespread religious freedoms limit the state's authority over the religious sphere. Because separating religion from state affairs is a principal tenet of such freedoms, meaningfully protecting them constrains the state's ability to regulate, alter, or manipulate religious life for political purposes. This has two major ramifications. The first concerns the state's capacity to target groups by religious identity. When its reach into the religious sphere is curtailed, a government is less able to deprive particular groups of

their liberties or restrict their practices, and such interventions become both less likely and harder to justify. Religious grievances therefore diminish, and groups are less likely to see violence as a necessary means of challenging oppression.

Moreover, where religious freedoms are widely institutionalized, political authorities are less able to grant preferential treatment to particular groups. By restraining state power in the religious sphere, such protections keep incumbents from conferring privileges on specific communities for political ends, so no group can secure exclusive state backing that others are denied. Terrorism aimed at defending a privileged position or extracting further concessions at rivals' expense thus becomes far less likely. This directly counters the *weapon of the strong* theory by eliminating the state-backed advantages that let dominant groups deploy violence against minorities.

I should clarify that I do not equate religious freedoms with the state's complete withdrawal from the religious sphere. Even where such freedoms are protected, states may retain some authority to regulate aspects of religious life, for instance, ensuring that groups can practice safely and peacefully, or providing public services that facilitate religious observance. In states with widespread religious freedoms, however, this role should in principle facilitate the exercise of these freedoms rather than manipulate or control religious life.

Finally, states with widespread religious freedoms undermine these groups' motivations through the legal implications of such protections. Institutionalized religious freedoms help ensure that legislation and legal practice apply equally to all citizens regardless of religious identity, reducing grievances and curbing the discriminatory legal practices that often fuel violence. They also deny dominant groups the legal protection of privileged status: rather than operating within a climate of impunity, all groups face legal accountability for violating the law, which raises the opportunity costs of terrorism. Therefore, my first hypothesis is:

H1: Countries with widespread religious freedom experience less religious terrorism compared to countries with severe restrictions on religious freedom.

Although widespread religious freedoms can confer advantages in mitigating religious terrorism, religious terrorist groups may still emerge and operate in these contexts, since a substantial literature identifies many factors behind the rise of terrorist organizations. Even so, I contend that such groups are likely to be more restrained in their use of violence than their counterparts in states with severe restrictions on religious freedom.

Several factors account for this difference. Most notably, as previously discussed, majority groups in countries with freedom of religion do not operate under conditions of impunity. Instead, they are subject to equal treatment under the law. As a result, when some groups may still choose to engage in terrorism, the prospect of legal accountability com-

pels them to act more strategically, often leading them to avoid widespread indiscriminate violence.

A similar logic applies to groups formed by minority religious communities. When they resort to terrorism, their attacks are typically driven by specific grievances such as policy changes harming their community or perceptions that the government is curbing their rights. Being small and resource-poor, these groups depend heavily on external support, especially from other religious groups that share their concerns now or might in the future. Consequently, when minority groups in states with widespread religious freedoms turn to terrorism, they are compelled to act strategically, avoiding indiscriminate violence so as not to alienate potential support or provoke strong opposition. In light of this logic, my second hypothesis is:

H2: Religious terrorist groups in countries with widespread religious freedoms are more restrained in their use of violence against domestic targets than groups in countries with severe restrictions on religious freedoms.

The next section describes my dataset, my dependent and independent variables, and the research design I use to test my hypotheses, after which I present and discuss the empirical results.

## 4 Research Design

To test these hypotheses, I draw on several data sources, constructing my dependent variables primarily from the Extended Data on Terrorist Groups (EDTG) (Hou et al. 2020) and the Global Terrorism Database (GTD) (START 2022). The EDTG, to my knowledge, offers the most comprehensive and up-to-date classification of terrorist groups by base country. It sorts groups into four categories as left-wing, nationalist, religious, and right-wing. Filtering groups only to the religious ones, I obtain the set of organization names that forms my sample.

Furthermore, the EDTG is also compatible with the GTD, the most comprehensive dataset on terrorist attacks worldwide (START 2022), which I subset to attacks by the religious terrorist organizations identified in the EDTG. The GTD defines a terrorist attack as “the threatened or actual use of illegal force and violence by a non-state actor to attain a political, economic, religious, or social goal through fear, coercion, or intimidation” (START 2021). To retain only reliably coded incidents, I keep observations satisfying all three GTD inclusion criteria and drop those flagged ambiguous by its “doubt” indicator. I detail the group-to-event matching procedure in the Appendix and list the included organizations in Appendix Table 4.

My second hypothesis concerns the *type* of attacks these groups conduct. The GTD codes an attack as domestic when the perpetrator and target share a nationality and as international when they differ. Following this distinction, I classify the matched EDTG-GTD attack data into domestic and international attacks. I also extract casualty data as an alternative measure of religious terrorism.

My primary independent variable comes from the CIRIGHTS Data Project, which builds quantitative indicators of globally recognized human rights across countries (Mark et al. 2024). I use its *Freedom of Religion* score, which the codebook defines as “the extent to which the freedom of citizens to exercise and practice their religious beliefs is subject to actual government restrictions” and codes in three ordinal categories: *Severe and Widespread*, *Moderate*, and *Practically Absent*. Crucially, its criteria weigh both the laws countries enact to protect religious freedom and governments’ actual practices, a distinction prior work stresses, given the frequent gap between formal protections and state behavior (Fox 2023). Capturing both dimensions lets me test my hypotheses while addressing that concern. Furthermore, unlike other prominent sources such as the Religion and State dataset (Fox 2019), Pew’s Government Restrictions Index (Pew Research Center 2026), and International Religious Freedom Reports (Grim and Finke 2011), CIRIGHTS provides annual scores since 1981, closely matching my analytical sample. I plot its country-year distribution in Appendix Figure 6 and report the within-country variation below.

Table 1: Within-Country Variation in Religious Freedom

|                                                          | By decade |       |       |       | Total |
|----------------------------------------------------------|-----------|-------|-------|-------|-------|
|                                                          | 1980s     | 1990s | 2000s | 2010s |       |
| <b>Panel A. Annual transition episodes, by direction</b> |           |       |       |       |       |
| Liberalizing (toward more freedom)                       | 147       | 180   | 190   | 84    | 601   |
| Restricting (toward less freedom)                        | 174       | 183   | 196   | 133   | 686   |
| All transitions                                          | 321       | 363   | 386   | 217   | 1,287 |
| <b>Panel B. Country treatment trajectory, 1981–2016</b>  |           |       |       |       |       |
| Countries with a transition                              | 98        | 112   | 105   | 106   | 161   |
| Persistent: always unrestricted                          |           |       | –     |       | 8     |
| Persistent: always moderate restrictions                 |           |       | –     |       | 1     |
| Persistent: always severe restrictions                   |           |       | –     |       | 2     |
| Total countries with coded treatment                     |           |       | –     |       | 172   |

*Notes:* Within-country variation in the CIRIGHTS religious-freedom variable, 1981–2016. A *transition* is a change in the freedom-of-religion category (0 = severe, 1 = moderate, 2 = unrestricted) between consecutive country-years. **Panel A** counts transition episodes by direction (liberalizing vs. restricting) and decade (1980s = 1981–1989, ..., 2010s = 2010–2016); episodes sum across decades. **Panel B** counts countries by trajectory: “Countries with a transition” gives the *distinct* countries with at least one transition per decade and over the full period (these do not sum across columns, as a country may transition in several decades), while the “persistent” rows count countries that never change category (dashes mark no per-decade breakdown).

I incorporate several control variables into my analysis. Given the established rela-

tionship between political regimes and terrorism (Eubank and Weinberg 1994; Li 2005; Chenoweth 2013; Magen 2018; Bogaards 2020), I include a measure of regime type into my empirical analysis. I also use the *Revised Combined Polity Score* from the Polity V dataset (Marshall and Gurr 2020). This score ranges from -10 (strongly autocratic) to 10 (strongly democratic) and includes adjustments for irregular or missing values, making the data more appropriate for time-series analysis by preserving temporal continuity.

Because prior research links poverty to terrorism (Krueger and Malečková 2003; Abadie 2006; Piazza 2006; Piazza 2011), I control for economic conditions with *GDP per capita* (current US dollars), and I include each country’s annual *population*, since more populous states may host more religious terrorist organizations. Both come from the World Bank Development Indicators (2025) and are log-transformed to mitigate scale and skewness. Because recent work ties corruption to terrorism (Meierrieks and Auer 2025), I add V-Dem’s *Political Corruption Index* (Coppedge et al. 2025), scaled 0-1 with higher values indicating more corruption. Finally, given the link between state capacity and terrorism (Piazza 2008), I include V-Dem’s *State authority over territory* variable, the percentage of a country’s territory under effective state control (0-100, higher values indicating greater control).

Finally, religious terrorist activity may also depend on ongoing armed conflict and religious fractionalization. On the former, scholarship documents substantial overlap between civil war and terrorism (Findley and Young 2012), with groups’ use of terrorism varying by their base of support (Fortna et al. 2018) and targets (Stanton 2013) and shaping both conflict outcomes (Findley and Young 2015; Thomas 2014) and eventual success (Fortna 2015). I therefore include a binary indicator from the UCDP/PRIO Armed Conflict Dataset (Gleditsch et al. 2002; Davies et al. 2025), coded 1 if the country is party to an active armed conflict that year and 0 otherwise. For religious fractionalization, I draw religious demographics from the Religious Characteristics of States Dataset (Brown and James 2019) and, following Alesina et al. (2003), compute it as  $1 - \sum s_i^2$ , the probability that two randomly drawn individuals belong to different religious groups, where  $s_i$  is the population share of religious group  $i$  across 15 major categories<sup>4</sup>.

I adopt a temporal scope of 1981 to 2016 for my sample data. To be more specific, I set the lower bound at 1981 because the CIRIGHTS Data Project, the source of my main independent variable measuring freedom of religion across countries, begins coding in that year (Mark et al. 2024). Furthermore, I set the upper bound at 2016 because the EDTG stops coding religious terrorist organizations and their countries in that year. The intersection of these two constraints defines the 1981-2016 period I adopt throughout my empirical analysis. Within this window, I determine country inclusion in my sample data

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<sup>4</sup>I exclude shares of unknown religious affiliation and renormalize the remaining shares to sum to one before applying this formula.

using the Gleditsch and Ward state system membership list (Gleditsch and Ward 1999). A country-year enters the panel only if the country is recognized as a sovereign state in the corresponding year. To that end, I estimate the following regression model:

$$Y_{it} = \beta_1 \text{Freedom of Religion}_{i,t-1} + \alpha_i + \xi_t + X_{i,t-1} + \varepsilon_{it} \quad (1)$$

Here,  $\xi_t$  denotes year fixed effects, absorbing global or regional shocks common to all countries in a given year, and  $\alpha_i$  denotes country fixed effects, controlling for time-invariant country characteristics.  $\text{Freedom of Religion}_{i,t-1}$  is the main explanatory variable, lagged one year to address reverse causality and temporal ordering, and the vector  $X_{i,t-1}$  collects the time-varying controls described above, likewise lagged one year. Finally,  $\varepsilon_{it}$  is the idiosyncratic error, capturing unobserved country-year influences not explained by the regressors.

## 5 Results

Before turning to the results for the empirical analysis, I present some descriptive statistics for my sample data. Below, I begin with mapping the distribution of religious terrorist organizations by their base country.

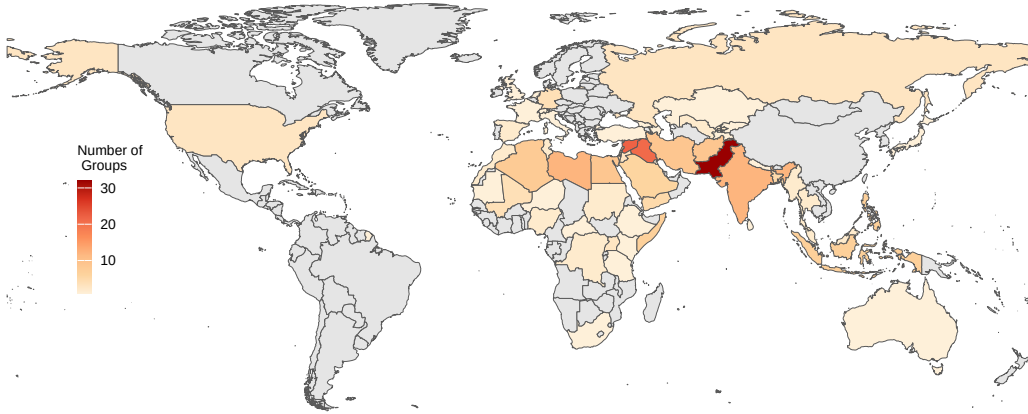


Figure 2: SPATIAL DISTRIBUTION OF RELIGIOUS TERRORIST ORGANIZATIONS. The figure includes only the religious terrorist organizations that were cross-matched across the EDTG and the GTD datasets, constituting the sample used in the empirical analysis (see the Appendix for details on the matching procedure). Note that a single group may be coded as being based in multiple countries according to the EDTG.

As Figure 2 shows, the religious terrorist organizations in my sample are not heavily

concentrated in any single region. Although most groups are based in the Middle East, North Africa, and parts of East Asia, regions commonly associated with weak state capacity, low levels of development, and limited political freedoms, the sample also includes groups operating under markedly different conditions, such as those based in Western Europe. At the same time, some regions with ostensibly similar structural conditions, most notably sub-Saharan Africa, have produced far fewer religious terrorist organizations than the Middle East and North Africa.

Beyond the geographic distribution of groups in my sample, below, I also examine the annual trends in attacks and resulting casualties carried out by the religious terrorist organizations in my sample. Figure 3 shows that the average number of domestic attacks per country is slightly higher than the average number of international attacks, and a similar pattern holds for casualties across most of the years in the sample. This suggests that religious terrorist organizations rely more heavily on domestic rather than international attacks, a pattern that future research might explore by investigating what motivates these organizations to favor domestic targets rather than international ones.

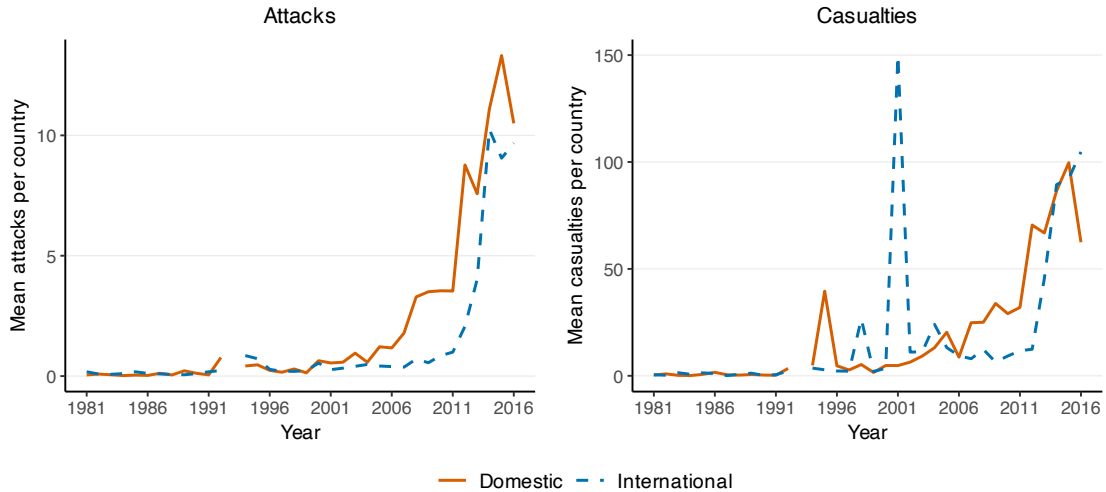


Figure 3: ANNUAL TRENDS IN RELIGIOUS TERRORIST GROUP ACTIVITY. Casualties are killed plus wounded (perpetrators excluded) from religious terrorist attacks, aggregated to country-year. The domestic/international split follows the GTD’s “International-Ideological” variable (INT\_IDEO), which compares perpetrator and target nationality rather than physical border-crossing. Year 1993 is missing from the GTD.

## 5.1 Empirical Results

Having analyzed the spatial distribution of religious terrorist organizations and their annual trends in attacks and casualties, I now turn to the empirical analysis to test my hypotheses. I estimate the model in Equation 1 using two-way fixed effects models, which absorb unobserved time-invariant country characteristics and common shocks across years

(Wooldridge 2010). To build confidence intervals for my point estimates, I calculate heteroskedasticity-robust standard errors clustered at the country and year levels. I report results for my first hypothesis in the following coefficient plot.

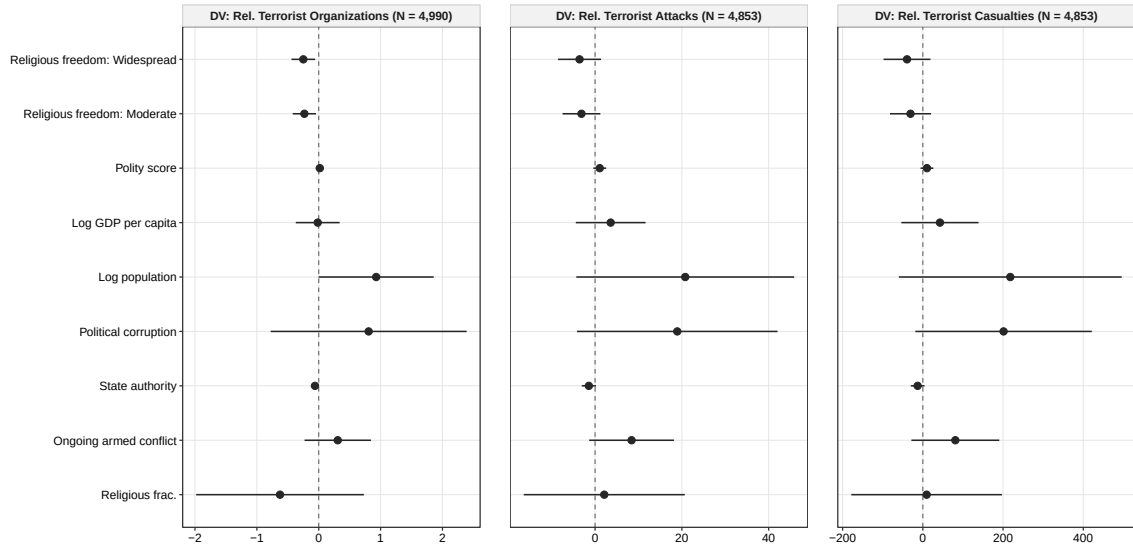


Figure 4: FREEDOM OF RELIGION AND RELIGIOUS TERRORISM. TWFE coefficient estimates across three dependent variables, each in its own panel. Models include country and year fixed effects, with standard errors two-way clustered by country and year and all explanatory variables lagged one year. Bars denote 95% confidence intervals. Full regression estimates appear in Appendix Table 6.

Figure 4 provides supporting evidence for my first hypothesis. Countries with widespread religious freedoms, relative to countries with severe state restrictions on religious practices (the omitted category), host significantly fewer religious terrorist organizations. The same pattern holds at moderate levels of freedom: these states also host fewer such organizations than those with severe restrictions. Note that both results are statistically significant at the conventional threshold ( $p < 0.05$ ).

A similar pattern emerges when I operationalize religious terrorism as the number of attacks and their associated casualties. States with high and moderate levels of religious freedom experience fewer religious terrorist attacks, and fewer resulting casualties, than states with severe restrictions. Nevertheless, while the coefficients are signed as expected, they fall short of conventional levels of statistical significance. Future work could examine the mechanisms behind this divergence, whereby religious freedom appears to shape the existence of terrorist groups more strongly than their activity.

Because the three dependent variables with which I measure religious terrorism are highly right-skewed and dominated by zeros, I assess the sensitivity of the results reported in Figure 4 to two alternative treatments of the outcome. I first re-estimate each specification after applying the log-plus-one transformation,  $\ln(1 + y)$ , to the dependent variable. Consistent with the main results, the coefficients on widespread religious freedom are

negative and statistically significant ( $p < 0.05$ ) across all three outcomes, as are those on moderate religious freedom.

However, estimating a log-linearized multiplicative model by OLS is known to be inconsistent under heteroskedasticity, since the expectation of the log-transformed error depends on the covariates (Santos Silva and Tenreyro 2006), and the problem worsens with many zeros, where transformations might yield estimates whose magnitude depends on the outcome's units (Chen and Roth 2024). I therefore re-estimate each specification as a Poisson model with country and year fixed effects, using the pseudo-maximum-likelihood (PPML) estimator, accommodating zeros without transforming the outcome. The coefficients on widespread and moderate religious freedom again remain negative across all three outcomes, except for a small positive moderate coefficient in the casualties model, but none is statistically significant at conventional levels. This attenuation is partly mechanical. The Poisson fixed-effects estimator drops countries whose outcome is zero in every year, substantially reducing the sample. I report these results in Appendix Table 7.

Next, I turn to test my second hypothesis. Recall that this hypothesis posits that even though religious terrorist organizations are less likely to emerge in countries having religious freedom, when they do, I claim that they will be more strategic in their use of violence. I suggest that this is because those groups will exercise greater restraint in deploying indiscriminate violence since the principal factors motivating religious violence are greatly attenuated in such contexts. Thus, they will less frequently resort to violence compared to other groups.

To test my second hypothesis, I subset the terrorist attacks data in the GTD using the “International – Ideological” variable, which codes the nationalities of perpetrator groups and their targets. When the two match, the attack is coded as domestic and when they differ, it is coded as international. I expect that the number of domestic attacks conducted by religious terrorist organizations will be lower in countries with freedom of religion compared to countries with severe restrictions. The table below reports the results.

Table 2: Religious Freedom and Religious Terrorism

|                                | <b>Domestic</b>   |                    | <b>International</b> |                    |
|--------------------------------|-------------------|--------------------|----------------------|--------------------|
|                                | Attacks           | Casualties         | Attacks              | Casualties         |
|                                | (1)               | (2)                | (3)                  | (4)                |
| Religious freedom: widespread  | -1.038<br>(0.109) | -11.098<br>(0.135) | -2.540<br>(0.233)    | -28.388<br>(0.231) |
| Religious freedom: moderate    | -0.546<br>(0.466) | -5.313<br>(0.513)  | -2.589<br>(0.167)    | -25.434<br>(0.232) |
| Polity score                   | 0.384*<br>(0.037) | 3.054<br>(0.053)   | 0.689<br>(0.273)     | 7.136<br>(0.294)   |
| Log GDP per capita             | 1.280<br>(0.361)  | 20.217<br>(0.277)  | 2.320<br>(0.464)     | 22.467<br>(0.529)  |
| Log population                 | 7.368<br>(0.113)  | 90.349<br>(0.079)  | 13.413<br>(0.187)    | 127.749<br>(0.242) |
| Political corruption           | 12.505<br>(0.138) | 119.719<br>(0.100) | 6.450<br>(0.286)     | 81.762<br>(0.218)  |
| State authority over territory | -0.528<br>(0.093) | -3.115<br>(0.086)  | -0.907<br>(0.153)    | -9.898<br>(0.161)  |
| Ongoing armed conflict         | 6.897<br>(0.142)  | 81.482<br>(0.130)  | 1.523<br>(0.331)     | -0.382<br>(0.979)  |
| Religious fractionalization    | 3.329<br>(0.489)  | 18.168<br>(0.704)  | -1.197<br>(0.816)    | -8.495<br>(0.875)  |
| Observations                   | 4853              | 4853               | 4853                 | 4853               |
| $R^2$                          | 0.673             | 0.379              | 0.197                | 0.180              |
| Adj. $R^2$                     | 0.659             | 0.352              | 0.162                | 0.145              |

Notes: OLS with two-way (country and year) fixed effects. Each cell gives the coefficient with the  $p$ -value in parentheses. Standard errors are heteroskedasticity-robust and two-way clustered by country and year; all regressors lagged one year. \*  $p < 0.05$ ; \*\*  $p < 0.01$ ; \*\*\*  $p < 0.001$ .

**Table 2** offers partial support for my second hypothesis. Religious terrorist groups operating in countries with widespread religious freedoms carry out fewer domestic attacks than groups in countries restricting such freedoms. This pattern is notable in light of religious terrorist organizations' general tendency to favor domestic over international targets, as illustrated in **Figure 3**. A similar case exists for casualties from domestic attacks: countries with widespread religious freedoms suffer fewer such casualties than countries with severe restrictions. Both coefficients are negative and of the expected sign. However, they fall short of conventional significance levels ( $p \approx 0.109$  for attacks and  $p \approx 0.135$  for casualties). I therefore read these results as suggestive rather than conclusive.

One data feature warrants attention: the GTD has no records for 1993, because the original event-level files were destroyed before digitization, a gap unrelated to religious freedom or terrorism. To confirm this does not drive the domestic-attack results, I re-estimate the models imputing each country's 1993 value as the mean of its 1992 and 1994

values (Appendix Table 8). The estimates are substantively unchanged: the coefficients on widespread and moderate religious freedom stay negative and similar in magnitude for domestic attacks and casualties, while the international-attack coefficients remain indistinguishable from zero. The domestic-attack coefficient becomes marginally more precise ( $p$ -value moves from  $\approx 0.109$  to just below 0.10). The negative association between religious freedom and domestic religious terrorism is thus not an artifact of the missing year, and religious terrorist organizations in freer countries appear more restrained domestically than internationally, consistent with my second hypothesis.

Even when the values for the year of 1993 are imputed, the widespread-freedom coefficient remains insignificant for casualties. One plausible reading is that groups exert meaningful control over whether and where to attack, but far less over how many casualties an attack produces, an outcome shaped by target hardening, emergency response, weapon performance, and chance. Attack counts may therefore be a cleaner measure of a group's strategic choices about violence than casualty counts, so these results are best read as suggestive rather than confirmatory.

## 6 Alternative Explanations and Robustness Tests

The results in the previous section provide supportive evidence for my hypotheses: countries with widespread religious freedoms host fewer religious terrorist organizations than those with strict restrictions, and even where such groups exist, they carry out fewer domestic attacks. This pattern being not extended to international attacks further strengthens my argument.

Because cross-national measurement of religious freedom is inherently imperfect, I reassess robustness using two alternative proxies from the Comparative Constitutions Project (CCP). The first records *whether a country's constitution designates an official religion*: I recode the original three-category variable as 0 when an official religion is specified or one or more receive special treatment, and 1 when a national religion is explicitly prohibited<sup>5</sup>, on the logic that official religions or preferential treatment imply more limited freedoms by discriminating against other faiths. The second indicates *whether the constitution guarantees freedom of religion* (1 if yes, 0 otherwise). I expect constitutions that guarantee religious freedom to be associated with fewer religious terrorist organizations, fewer domestic attacks, and fewer casualties, and report the results below.

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<sup>5</sup>The CCP codebook's three original categories are: (1) national religion specified; (2) certain religion(s) enjoy special treatment; and (3) national religion specifically forbidden. Because roughly half the sample is missing on this variable and only 278 observations fall in the second category, I collapse it into a binary measure.

Table 3: Religious Freedoms and Religious Terrorism with Alternative Proxies

|                                | Religious groups based |                    | Domestic attacks  |                    | Domestic casualties |                     |
|--------------------------------|------------------------|--------------------|-------------------|--------------------|---------------------|---------------------|
|                                | (1)                    | (2)                | (3)               | (4)                | (5)                 | (6)                 |
| Religious freedom clause       | -0.290<br>(0.105)      |                    | -1.294<br>(0.380) |                    | -16.209<br>(0.346)  |                     |
| No-establishment clause        |                        | -0.590<br>(0.183)  |                   | -5.461<br>(0.063)  |                     | -50.790<br>(0.082)  |
| Polity score                   | 0.021<br>(0.286)       | 0.062<br>(0.138)   | 0.246<br>(0.170)  | 0.720<br>(0.067)   | 2.736<br>(0.225)    | 7.313<br>(0.140)    |
| Log GDP per capita             | 0.171<br>(0.155)       | 0.370<br>(0.099)   | 1.260<br>(0.258)  | 3.430<br>(0.182)   | 24.153<br>(0.131)   | 45.501<br>(0.114)   |
| Log population                 | 0.954*<br>(0.026)      | 1.003<br>(0.088)   | 5.435<br>(0.198)  | 7.799<br>(0.293)   | 74.984<br>(0.137)   | 103.742<br>(0.206)  |
| Political corruption           | 0.316<br>(0.416)       | 0.924<br>(0.324)   | 3.384<br>(0.254)  | 7.841<br>(0.370)   | 50.020<br>(0.153)   | 117.256<br>(0.219)  |
| State authority over territory | -0.037<br>(0.113)      | -0.080<br>(0.053)  | -0.124<br>(0.425) | -0.515<br>(0.123)  | -1.199<br>(0.540)   | -2.787<br>(0.309)   |
| Ongoing armed conflict         | -0.013<br>(0.922)      | -0.020<br>(0.920)  | 6.088<br>(0.169)  | 11.391<br>(0.110)  | 67.978<br>(0.178)   | 112.181<br>(0.158)  |
| Religious fractionalization    | -0.830<br>(0.087)      | -3.174*<br>(0.037) | 1.305<br>(0.694)  | -10.507<br>(0.395) | 9.072<br>(0.812)    | -115.116<br>(0.376) |
| Observations                   | 4467                   | 2297               | 4351              | 2243               | 4351                | 2243                |
| $R^2$                          | 0.859                  | 0.876              | 0.752             | 0.752              | 0.442               | 0.519               |
| Adj. $R^2$                     | 0.853                  | 0.868              | 0.740             | 0.735              | 0.416               | 0.486               |

*Notes:* OLS with two-way (country and year) fixed effects. Each cell gives the coefficient with the  $p$ -value in parentheses. Standard errors are heteroskedasticity-robust and two-way clustered by country and year; all regressors lagged one year. Within each pair, the first column reports the religious-freedom-clause specification, the second the no-establishment-clause specification. Both predictors are binary recodings of Comparative Constitutions Project (CCP) indicators: “Religious freedom clause” = 1 if the constitution guarantees freedom of religion, “No-establishment clause” = 1 if it forbids a national religion. Coverage of the two CCP variables differs, so sample size varies across columns. Year 1993 is missing from the GTD-derived outcomes in columns (3)–(6). \*  $p < 0.05$ ; \*\*  $p < 0.01$ ; \*\*\*  $p < 0.001$ .

Using alternative proxies for freedom of religion, [Table 3](#) reveals a pattern consistent with my main findings. Countries whose constitutions contain a freedom of religion clause, and those that constitutionally forbid an established religion, host fewer religious terrorist organizations, face fewer domestic religious terrorist attacks, and experience fewer casualties. All six coefficients are negative and point in the hypothesized direction.

However, their statistical significance is uneven. Among the religious freedom-clause specifications, only the organizations model (Model 1) approaches conventional levels ( $p \approx 0.105$ ). The coefficients for domestic attacks (Model 3,  $p \approx 0.380$ ) and casualties (Model 5,  $p \approx 0.346$ ) are far from being statistically significant. The no-establishment measure performs more strongly: although its coefficient is insignificant for organizations (Model 2,  $p \approx 0.183$ ), it is marginally significant ( $p < 0.10$ ) for both domestic attacks (Model 4) and casualties (Model 6). Substantively, this implies that countries whose constitutions designate an official religion experience both more attacks and more casualties than those

that forbid one.

I read this mixed pattern in light of the proxy variables' two features. First, their coverage is limited and uneven: because the CCP codes constitutional text directly, constitutions silent on a coding question or falling into an "Other" category are treated as missing, sharply reducing the effective sample, especially for the no-establishment measure, and limits precision. Second, constitutional text and actual state behavior often diverge on religion, which is why I treat CIRIGHTS as my preferred proxy. Overall, although these alternative specifications are at times statistically insignificant, their coefficients' direction consistently suggest that countries with greater religious freedom are better positioned to contain religious terrorism, offering suggestive support for my hypotheses.

## 6.1 Majority Religions

Another concern is that my results may depend on a country's majority religion, which could shape the hypothesized mechanisms. I therefore restrict the sample to Muslim- and Christian-majority countries, the world's two most widely practiced traditions, classifying a country as Muslim- (Christian-) majority if its mean Muslim (Christian) population share over the study period is at least 50%, and re-estimate the main specifications on each subsample (Appendix Table 9). Across almost every outcome (organizations, attacks, and casualties), the coefficient on religious freedom is no longer distinguishable from zero. The sole exception is that, among Christian-majority countries, widespread religious freedoms are associated with fewer attacks, significant at the 90% level ( $p \approx 0.08$ ).

## 6.2 Do changes in countries' religious freedoms affect the religious terrorism they experience?

In the analyses presented so far, I demonstrate a robust association between a country's level of religious freedom and the religious terrorism it experiences. However, one question still remains unanswered is whether changes in countries' religious freedoms translate into corresponding changes in religious terrorism they face. If my theory is correct, I should observe that countries improving their religious freedoms should subsequently have fewer religious terrorist groups and experience fewer casualties than countries that do not.

To examine that, I conduct a further analysis. Drawing on recent advances in matching methods for causal inference with panel data (Imai et al. 2023), I estimate the effect of within-country changes in religious freedom on the level of religious terrorism a country faces. Because this method requires a binary treatment, I recode the CIRIGHTS religious freedom variable to equal 1 for country-years coded as *Widespread Religious Freedom* and 0 otherwise. In the Appendix Figure 7, I report results from an alternative recoding strategy

that collapses *Widespread* and *Moderate Religious Freedom* into the treatment category (1) and retains *Severe Restrictions* as the control (0).

I implement the analysis with the PanelMatch package in R (Imai et al. 2023). For each treated country-year, the estimator builds a matched set of up to five control units that are untreated in the focal year and share its three-period pre-treatment history, then refines them by Mahalanobis distance on the baseline covariates measured in each of the three pre-treatment years. I trace the resulting ATT estimates from  $t + 0$ , when treatment switches on, through  $t + 8$ , and report covariate balance in Appendix Table 10. The table below reports the results.

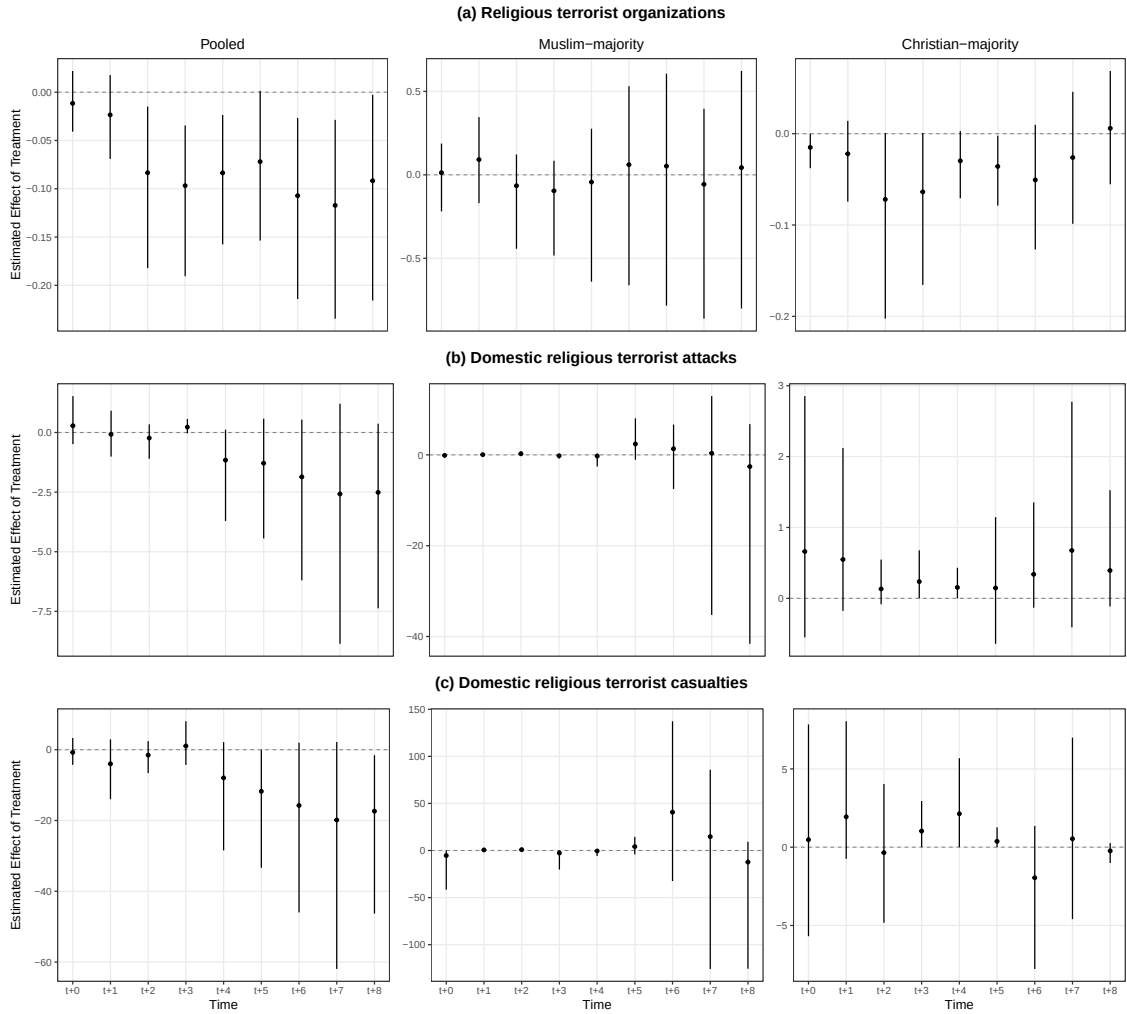


Figure 5: IMPACT OF RELIGIOUS FREEDOMS ON RELIGIOUS TERRORISM. Estimated ATT effects of religious freedom on three outcomes, all per country-year. Columns give the pooled sample (left), Muslim-majority (middle), and Christian-majority (right) countries, where majority membership is a country-level mean population share of at least 50% across the sample. The binary treatment equals one in country-years with widespread freedom of religion and zero otherwise, with treatment reversal allowed. Vertical bars are 95% bootstrap confidence intervals (1,000 iterations).

Figure 5 provides evidence consistent with my hypotheses. In the pooled sample, once

a country transitions from severe restrictions on religious practice into the widespread-freedom category, the number of religious terrorist organizations based there begins to decline about two years after treatment, an effect that reaches conventional significance ( $p < 0.05$ ). A parallel pattern holds for domestic religious terrorist attacks and their associated casualties: about four years after treatment, treated countries face fewer domestic attacks and fewer resulting casualties than their matched controls, although both estimates fall just short of conventional significance. Taken together, these results support my main hypothesis. Once countries move to widespread religious freedom, they host significantly fewer religious terrorist organizations and appear to experience fewer domestic attacks and casualties, though the latter two effects are estimated with less precision.

As auxiliary tests, I re-estimate the same specifications on the Muslim- and Christian-majority subsamples (middle and right columns of [Figure 5](#)), and the results diverge. For organizations, widespread religious freedom is associated with significantly fewer groups in the Christian-majority subsample, mirroring the pooled finding, but the Muslim-majority estimate, though similarly signed, is indistinguishable from zero, a gap I read as one of precision rather than of the underlying effect, since the Muslim-majority analysis rests on just 22 treated countries (30 treated country-years) versus 73 (164) and yields wider confidence intervals throughout. The attacks and casualties results are more discordant: entering the widespread-freedom category has no significant effect on domestic attacks or casualties for Muslim-majority countries, whereas for Christian-majority countries it runs against expectation, producing more domestic attacks and casualties in the first post-treatment years before the effect attenuates and loses significance. Because these estimates rest on few treated switches and casualties are driven by a handful of high-fatality country-years, I treat all subsample patterns as exploratory rather than as evidence against the pooled results.

## 7 Conclusion

In this paper, I examined the relationship between freedom of religion and religious terrorism. I argued that countries adopting religious freedoms can better address the two main causes of religious violence, compared to countries having severe restrictions on religious practices. First, I posited those countries with freedom of religion are better able to defuse the grievances driving violent religious mobilization and are therefore more resilient against religious terrorism deployed as a weapon of the weak. Furthermore, shielding religious minorities from repression at the hands of the state or of dominant religious groups, these countries are also more protected when religious terrorism was conducted as a weapon of the strong.

Based on this theoretical framework, I derived my hypotheses such that (i) countries

with widespread religious freedoms should face fewer religious terrorist organizations and (ii) experience less domestic religious terrorism than countries that severely restrict religious practice. The results from my empirical analyses lend support to my expectations. Results from two-way fixed-effects (TWFE) models demonstrated that countries with widespread religious freedoms have significantly less religious terrorist groups and, where such groups exist, they conduct fewer domestic attacks compared to groups in countries with severe restrictions on religious freedoms.

Because measuring freedom of religion is difficult across time and space and there are different data sources having different temporal scopes, I also re-ran my main specifications using alternative proxies. The findings remain directionally robust, although they occasionally lose conventional significance.

To go beyond an associational reading, I conducted a final analysis exploiting within-country changes in freedom of religion. Using a matching-based estimator designed for causal inference with panel data, I recovered estimates of the average treatment effect on the treated. The pattern carries through. Once a country moves into the widespread-freedom category, it hosts fewer religious terrorist organizations and faces fewer domestic attacks from them.

Nevertheless, several questions remain open. Most importantly, while my findings show that countries with widespread religious freedoms are more resilient against religious terrorism, we still know little about why states liberalize or restrict religious freedom in the first place. This question is particularly pressing given that, as [Table 1](#) shows, a substantial number of countries changed their level of religious freedom over the period examined in this study.

Furthermore, my empirical analyses indicate that religious freedoms shape the existence of terrorist groups more strongly than their activity, which I measure by the number of attacks these groups conduct and the resulting casualties. Future research could examine this divergence more closely and identify the mechanisms that account for it.

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## 9 Appendix

### 9.1 Data Matching Process between the EDTG and the GTD

The empirical analysis combines group-level information from the Extended Data on Terrorist Groups (EDTG) (Hou et al. 2020) with event-level records from the Global Terrorism Database (GTD) (START 2022). The EDTG classifies each organization by its primary ideological motivation, left-wing, nationalist, religious, or right-wing, and identifies the country (or countries) in which the group is based. The GTD, in turn, records every terrorist attack satisfying its inclusion criteria along with the perpetrating organization. In that regard, the two datasets are explicitly designed to be compatible. Indeed, in its original release, the EDTG reports group-year aggregates such as annual counts of attacks and fatalities based on the GTD. However, it does not distinguish whether an attack is ideologically domestic or international given its group-level data structure. To recover this information, I work directly with the GTD’s attack-level records, restricting them to attacks attributed to the religious terrorist organizations I identify by a cross-matching process between the GTD and the EDTG. In the following, I elaborate this cross-matching process.

Despite the intended compatibility across the EDTG and the GTD, several reasons prevent a one-to-one match on raw group names across these two datasets. Examples include differences in transliteration (“Al-Qaeda” in the EDTG versus “Al-Qaida” in the GTD), in the presence or absence of geographic qualifiers (the EDTG’s “Ansar al-Dine” appears as “Ansar al-Dine (Mali)” in the GTD), and occasionally in the granularity of the entries themselves: the Jewish Defense League, for instance, appears twice in the EDTG under the suffixes “(JDL)\_1” and “(JDL)\_2”, while it is only coded as JDL in the GTD. I reconcile these linguistic inconsistencies in two stages: an algorithmic pass that matches groups with identical names, followed by manual review of the remaining cases.

In this matching process, I deliberately chose not to rely only on a loose string-distance threshold to match group names between the EDTG and the GTD. A permissive cutoff would, in fact, catch more candidates easily, but the matches it returns depend heavily on where the threshold is set and can quietly introduce false positives, organizations with similar names but unrelated histories, that a reader cannot verify and that would contaminate my statistical results. The two-stage approach below addresses this by keeping the automated step strict (exact matches only), limiting judgment calls to a manual review of the top five candidates, and recording every resulting alias in a single auditable file. I describe the procedure in detail below.

**Step 1: Normalize names, collapse duplicate entries, and remove the ARGK.** First, I filter the full EDTG group-year data to organizations coded as religious terrorist groups and lowercase their names to absorb casing differences. I then collapse the two Jewish Defense League records into a single entry. As a final action in this step, I manually drop the People’s Liberation Army of Kurdistan (ARGK), the military wing of the PKK and a Marxist-Leninist organization from this list. I confirm this decision with the EDTG authors that the organization had been miscoded as a religious terrorist group. This process yields a list of 201 unique religious terrorist organizations according to the EDTG.

**Step 2: Exact matching via Jaro–Winkler distance.** Following the first step, I match the EDTG religious terrorist groups list against the perpetrator-group information in the GTD event-level data. Before matching, I restrict the GTD to attacks satisfying the database’s three standard inclusion criteria (`crit1`, `crit2`, and `crit3`) and exclude any event flagged

as ambiguous in the `doubtterr` indicator, so that the match is performed against the same event-level sample used in the analysis. The join itself uses Jaro–Winkler string distance via the `stringdist` package in R (Loo 2014). With the distance threshold set to zero, it accepts only exact matches after lowercasing, a deliberately conservative choice I make to prevent any misleading matches. This first pass matches 157 of the 201 EDTG entries to GTD perpetrators, leaving 44 unmatched groups.

**Step 3: Candidate surfacing for the unmatched groups.** For each of these 44 unmatched EDTG group names, I compute Jaro–Winkler distances to every GTD perpetrator name and retrieve the five nearest GTD candidates. I then inspect each candidate manually, consulting the textual description fields in both datasets and external organizational profiles through online search when in doubt. Where I find a candidate referring to the same organization as the EDTG entry, I record the alias in a crosswalk file (`name_crosswalk.csv`). However, when no candidate is a credible match based on my manual research, I leave this group name from the EDTG unrenamed. This manual review yields 38 verified aliases, which I record in the crosswalk file.

**Step 4: Second-pass match using the crosswalk.** After manual cross-matching, I re-run the Jaro–Winkler exact join rewriting EDTG names according to the crosswalk. Of the 38 aliases, 37 produce a new exact match when the join is re-run on the filtered GTD. The remaining alias points to a perpetrator group name, *Aisha Umm-al Mouemeneen*, that exists in the raw GTD but is excluded by the inclusion filters applied in Step 2. This brings the cumulative match count to 194 of the 201 EDTG entries.

**Step 5: Unified analysis set.** I list the names of the **194 religious terrorist organizations** that are cross-matched across the GTD and the EDTG Table 4. Given that the total number of religious terrorist organizations detected in the EDTG is 201, 7 organizations are excluded from the analysis as a result of this cross-match procedure because of two main reasons. First, 6 of them are entries for which the manual review in Step 3 found no credible GTD candidate. Those organizations are *the Abu Bakr al-Siddiq Fundamentalists Brigades (Iraq)*, *the Abu Hafs al-Masri Brigades*, *Ansar Al-Khilafa*, *Islamic Resistance*, *the Mujahideen Youth Movement*, and *Saif-ul-Muslimeen*. Second, 1 entry, *Aisha Umm-al Mouemeneen*, has a verified crosswalk alias whose GTD target is removed by the inclusion filters applied in Step 2, so the rename produces no new match (as noted in Step 4 above). The full EDTG–GTD crosswalk, including this entry, is listed in Appendix Table 5.

In addition to this data matching process on group names, it should also be noted that the EDTG and GTD occasionally disagree about whether a given organization was active in a given year. For instance, the EDTG may record a group as ceased while the GTD records that same group perpetrating attacks in subsequent years. To prevent these disagreements from asymmetrically affecting the statistical results for the first and second hypotheses, I treat the two databases symmetrically through a group-year imputation step. To be more specific, for each GTD-attested year that is absent from EDTG’s record for a matched group, I append an EDTG group-year record using the base country (or countries) from the closest EDTG year on file for that group, measured by absolute distance in years. For example, a group EDTG codes as ceased in 1975 with a GTD attack in 1986 is treated as active in 1986 with its 1975 base country. This expansion adds 188 group-year rows across 70 of the 194 organizations.

Finally, please note that in a small number of cases the GTD attributes a single attack to multiple perpetrator groups, reflecting competing claims of responsibility or overlapping attributions. Following standard practice in the literature, I rely on the perpetrator name recorded in the `gname` column of the original GTD release.

## 9.2 List of Religious Terrorist Organizations

Table 4: List of Religious Terrorist Organizations in the Sample Data. An asterisk (\*) marks an organization whose EDTG name was manually mapped to its GTD spelling after a stringdist-based candidate review (see the data-matching appendix above for the procedure). The asterisk is therefore a flag for entries that depended on manual judgment, not a substantive property of the organization.

| Group                                                        | Group                                               |
|--------------------------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------|
| 1920 Revolution Brigades                                     | Islamic State Of Iraq And The Levant (Isil)         |
| 313 Brigade (Syria)*                                         | Islamic Unification Movement                        |
| Abdullah Azzam Brigades                                      | Islamic Youth Shura Council                         |
| Abu Salim Martyr's Brigade                                   | Jabha East Africa                                   |
| Abu Sayyaf Group (Asg)                                       | Jaish Al-Adl                                        |
| Adan Abyan Islamic Army (Aaia)*                              | Jaish Al-Fatah (Syria)*                             |
| Ahlu-Sunah Wal-Jamea (Somalia)                               | Jaish Al-Muhajireen Wal-Ansar<br>(Muhajireen Army)* |
| Ahrar Al-Sham                                                | Jaish Al-Mujahideen (Syria)                         |
| Ajnad Al-Sham                                                | Jaish Al-Ta'ifa Al-Mansura                          |
| Ajnad Misr                                                   | Jaish Al-Umma (Army Of The Nation)                  |
| Al-Furqan Brigades                                           | Jaish Usama                                         |
| Al-Gama'at Al-Islamiyya (Ig)                                 | Jaish-E-Islam                                       |
| Al-Haramayn Brigades                                         | Jaish-E-Mohammad (Jem)                              |
| Al-Intiqami Al-Pakistani                                     | Jama'atul Mujahideen Bangladesh (Jmb)               |
| Al-Islah Party                                               | Jamaah Ansharut Daulah                              |
| Al-Ittihaad Al-Islami (Aiai)*                                | Jamaah Ansharut Tauhid (Jat)                        |
| Al-Khobar                                                    | Jamaat-E-Islami (Bangladesh)                        |
| Al-Mua'qi'oon Biddam Brigade (Those Who<br>Sign With Blood)* | Jamaat-Ul-Ahrar                                     |
| Al-Naqshabandiya Army                                        | Jamiat Ul-Mujahedin (Jum)                           |
| Al-Nusrah Front                                              | Jemaah Islamiya (Ji)                                |
| Al-Qaida*                                                    | Jewish Defense League (Jdl)                         |
| Al-Qaida In Iraq                                             | Jihadi Movement Of The Sunna People Of<br>Iran      |
| Al-Qaida In The Arabian Peninsula (Aqap)*                    | Jordanian Islamic Resistance                        |
| Al-Qaida In The Indian Subcontinent                          | Jund Al-Aqsa                                        |
| Al-Qaida In The Islamic Maghreb (Aqim)                       | Jund Al-Khilafa                                     |
| Al-Qaqa Brigade                                              | Jund Al-Sham For Tawhid And Jihad                   |
| Al-Sadr Brigades                                             | Jund Ansar Allah                                    |
| Al-Shabaab                                                   | Jundallah (Iran)*                                   |
| Al-Umar Mujahideen                                           | Jundallah (Pakistan)                                |
| Al-Ummah                                                     | Jundul Khilafah (Philippines)                       |
| Al-Yakin Mujahidin                                           | Kach                                                |
| Algeria Province Of The Islamic State                        | Kahane Chai                                         |
| Allied Democratic Forces (Adf)*                              | Kata'ib Hezbollah                                   |
| Amr Bil Maroof Wa Nahi Anil Munkir                           | Khorasan Chapter Of The Islamic State               |
| Ananda Marga                                                 | Komando Jihad (Indonesian)                          |
| Ansar Al-Din Front                                           | Lahij Province Of The Islamic State                 |
| Ansar Al-Dine (Mali)*                                        | Lashkar-E-Islam (Pakistan)*                         |

(continued on next page)

*(continued from previous page)*

| Group                                                | Group                                                  |
|------------------------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------|
| Ansar Al-Furqan                                      | Lashkar-E-Jhangvi                                      |
| Ansar Al-Islam                                       | Lashkar-E-Omar*                                        |
| Ansar Al-Jihad                                       | Lashkar-E-Taiba (Let)                                  |
| Ansar Al-Sharia (Libya)                              | Laskar Jihad*                                          |
| Ansar Al-Sunna*                                      | Lord's Resistance Army (Lra)                           |
| Ansar Allah                                          | Macina Liberation Front (Flm)*                         |
| Ansar Bayt Al-Maqdis (Ansar Jerusalem)               | Maute Group                                            |
| Ansar Wa Mohajir (Pakistan)                          | Moro Islamic Liberation Front (Milf)                   |
| Ansaru (Jama'atu Ansarul Muslimina Fi Biladis Sudan) | Moro National Liberation Front (Mnlf)                  |
| Ansarul Islam (Pakistan)*                            | Mouhajiroune Brigade                                   |
| Ansarullah Bangla Team                               | Movement For Oneness And Jihad In West Africa (Mujao)* |
| Anti-Balaka Militia*                                 | Movement Of Islamic Action Of Iraq                     |
| Armed Islamic Group (Gia)                            | Mujahedeen Army                                        |
| Army Of Islam                                        | Mujahedeen Shura Council                               |
| Asa'ib Ahl Al-Haqq                                   | Mujahedeen Shura Council In The Environs Of Jerusalem  |
| Asbat Al-Ansar                                       | Mujahideen Ansar                                       |
| Aum Shinri Kyo*                                      | Mujahidin Indonesia Timur (Mit)                        |
| Bahrain Province Of The Islamic State                | Mukhtar Army                                           |
| Barqa Province Of The Islamic State                  | Mullah Dadullah Front                                  |
| Benghazi Defense Brigades (Bdb)*                     | Muslim Brotherhood                                     |
| Black Hand                                           | Muslim United Army (Mua)*                              |
| Bodu Bala Sena                                       | Muslim United Liberation Tigers Of Assam (Multa)*      |
| Boko Haram                                           | Muslims Against Global Oppression (Mago)*              |
| Brigade Of Al-Mukhtar Al-Thaqafi                     | Najd Province Of The Islamic State                     |
| Brigades Of Imprisoned Sheikh Omar Abdel-Rahman      | Nur-Al-Din Al-Zinki Movement                           |
| Caucasus Emirate                                     | Okba Ibn Nafaa Brigade                                 |
| Caucasus Province Of The Islamic State               | Palestinian Islamic Jihad (Pij)                        |
| Deccan Mujahideen                                    | Pattani United Liberation Organization (Pulo)          |
| Dukhta-Ran-E-Millat                                  | People's United Liberation Front (Pulf)*               |
| Fatah Al-Islam                                       | Qari Kamran Group                                      |
| February 17 Martyrs Brigade                          | Raskamboni Movement                                    |
| Fezzan Province Of The Islamic State                 | Rohingya Solidarity Organization                       |
| Generation Of Arab Fury                              | Runda Kumpulan Kecil (Rkk)                             |
| Guardsmen Of Islam                                   | Salafia Jihadia                                        |
| Haqqani Network                                      | Salafist Group For Preaching And Fighting (Gspc)       |
| Harakat Al-Nujaba                                    | Samyukta Jatiya Mukti Morcha (Sjmm)*                   |
| Harakat Ansar Iran (Hai)                             | Sanaa Province Of The Islamic State                    |
| Harakat Ul-Mujahidin (Hum)*                          | Shamiya Front                                          |
| Harkatul Jihad-E-Islami                              | Sheikh Omar Hadid Brigade                              |

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| <b>Group</b>                                             | <b>Group</b>                                                      |
|----------------------------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Hezbollah                                                | Shield Of Islam Brigade                                           |
| Hijaz Province Of The Islamic State                      | Shura Council Of Benghazi Revolutionaries                         |
| Hizb Al-Tahrir Al-Islami (Ht)                            | Shura Council Of Mujahideen In Derna                              |
| Hizb-I-Islami*                                           | Sinai Province Of The Islamic State                               |
| Hizbul Al Islam (Somalia)*                               | Sipah-E-Sahaba/Pakistan (Ssp)*                                    |
| Hizbul Mujahideen (Hm)                                   | Sipah-I-Mohammed                                                  |
| Indian Mujahideen                                        | Students Islamic Movement Of India (Simi)                         |
| International Justice Group (Gama'a Al-Adela Al-Alamiya) | Takfir Wal-Hijra (Excommunication And Exodus)*                    |
| Iraq's Jihadist Leagues                                  | Taliban                                                           |
| Islami Jamiat-E-Talaba (Ijt)                             | Tawhid And Jihad                                                  |
| Islamic Army In Iraq (Al-Jaish Al-Islami Fi Al-Iraq)*    | Tehrik-E-Galba Islam                                              |
| Islamic Courts Union (Icu)*                              | Tehrik-E-Nafaz-E-Shariat-E-Mohammadi (Tnsm)                       |
| Islamic Front (Syria)                                    | Tehrik-E-Tuhafaz (Pakistan)                                       |
| Islamic Jihad Brigades                                   | Tehrik-I-Taliban Pakistan (Ttp)*                                  |
| Islamic Jihad Group (Ijg)                                | The Association For Islamic Mobilisation And Propagation (Uamsho) |
| Islamic Movement For Change                              | Tripoli Province Of The Islamic State                             |
| Islamic Movement Of Kashmir                              | Turkish Hezbollah*                                                |
| Islamic Movement Of Uzbekistan (Imu)*                    | Uganda Democratic Christian Army (Udca)                           |
| Islamic Salvation Front (Fis)                            | United Jihad Council                                              |
| Islamic State In Bangladesh                              | Yarmouk Martyrs Brigade                                           |
| Islamic State In The Greater Sahara (Isgs)*              | Zuwar Al-Imam Rida                                                |

### 9.3 EDTG-to-GTD Name Crosswalk

Table 5: EDTG-to-GTD name crosswalk. Each row records a manually verified alias decision made after the stringdist-based candidate review documented in the data-matching appendix above: the left column gives the EDTG perpetrator name, the right column gives the GTD perpetrator name it was mapped to. 37 of these 38 renames produce a successful match against GTD's inclusion-filtered event data; the remaining entry (*Aisha Umm-al Mouemeneen*) points to a perpetrator group name in the GTD that is removed by the inclusion filters applied across the GTD observations and therefore does not appear in Appendix Table 4.

| EDTG Name                                     | GTD Name                                                 |
|-----------------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------|
| 313 Brigade                                   | 313 Brigade (Syria)                                      |
| Adan Abyan Islamic Army                       | Adan Abyan Islamic Army (Aaia)                           |
| Aisha Umm-Al Mouemeneen                       | Aisha Umm-Al Mouemeneen (Brigades Of Aisha)              |
| Al Qaeda In The Arabian Peninsula (Aqap)      | Al-Qaida In The Arabian Peninsula (Aqap)                 |
| Al-Ittihaad Al-Islami                         | Al-Ittihaad Al-Islami (Aiai)                             |
| Al-Mua'qi'oon Biddam Brigade                  | Al-Mua'qi'oon Biddam Brigade (Those Who Sign With Blood) |
| Al-Qaeda                                      | Al-Qaida                                                 |
| Allied Democratic Forces                      | Allied Democratic Forces (Adf)                           |
| Ansar Al-Dine                                 | Ansar Al-Dine (Mali)                                     |
| Ansar Al-Sunnah Army                          | Ansar Al-Sunna                                           |
| Ansarul Islam(Pakistan)                       | Ansarul Islam (Pakistan)                                 |
| Anti-Balaka                                   | Anti-Balaka Militia                                      |
| Aum Shinrikyo                                 | Aum Shinri Kyo                                           |
| Benghazi Defense Brigades                     | Benghazi Defense Brigades (Bdb)                          |
| Harkat Ul-Mujahedin                           | Harakat Ul-Mujahidin (Hum)                               |
| Hekmatyar (Hizb-I Islami Gulbuddin)           | Hizb-I-Islami                                            |
| Hizbul Al Islam                               | Hizbul Al Islam (Somalia)                                |
| Islamic Army In Iraq                          | Islamic Army In Iraq (Al-Jaish Al-Islami Fi Al-Iraq)     |
| Islamic Courts Union                          | Islamic Courts Union (Icu)                               |
| Islamic Movement Of Uzbekistan                | Islamic Movement Of Uzbekistan (Imu)                     |
| Islamic State In The Greater Sahara           | Islamic State In The Greater Sahara (Isgs)               |
| Jaish Al-Fatah                                | Jaish Al-Fatah (Syria)                                   |
| Jaish Al-Muhajireen Wal-Ansar                 | Jaish Al-Muhajireen Wal-Ansar (Muhajireen Army)          |
| Jundallah(Iran)                               | Jundallah (Iran)                                         |
| Lashkar-E-Islam                               | Lashkar-E-Islam (Pakistan)                               |
| Lashkar-I-Omar                                | Lashkar-E-Omar                                           |
| Laskar Jihad (Lj)                             | Laskar Jihad                                             |
| Macina Liberation Front                       | Macina Liberation Front (Flm)                            |
| Movement For Oneness And Jihad In West Africa | Movement For Oneness And Jihad In West Africa (Mujao)    |
| Muslim United Army                            | Muslim United Army (Mua)                                 |
| Muslim United Liberation Tigers Of Assam      | Muslim United Liberation Tigers Of Assam (Multa)         |

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| <b>EDTG Name</b>                  | <b>GTD Name</b>                               |
|-----------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------|
| Muslims Against Global Oppression | Muslims Against Global Oppression (Mago)      |
| People's United Liberation Front  | People's United Liberation Front (Pulf)       |
| Samyukta Jatiya Mukti Morcha      | Samyukta Jatiya Mukti Morcha (Sjmm)           |
| Sipah-E-Sahaba Pakistan           | Sipah-E-Sahaba/Pakistan (Ssp)                 |
| Takfir Wa Hijra                   | Takfir Wal-Hijra (Excommunication And Exodus) |
| Tehrik-I-Taliban Pakistan(Ttp)    | Tehrik-I-Taliban Pakistan (Ttp)               |
| Turkish Hizballah                 | Turkish Hezbollah                             |

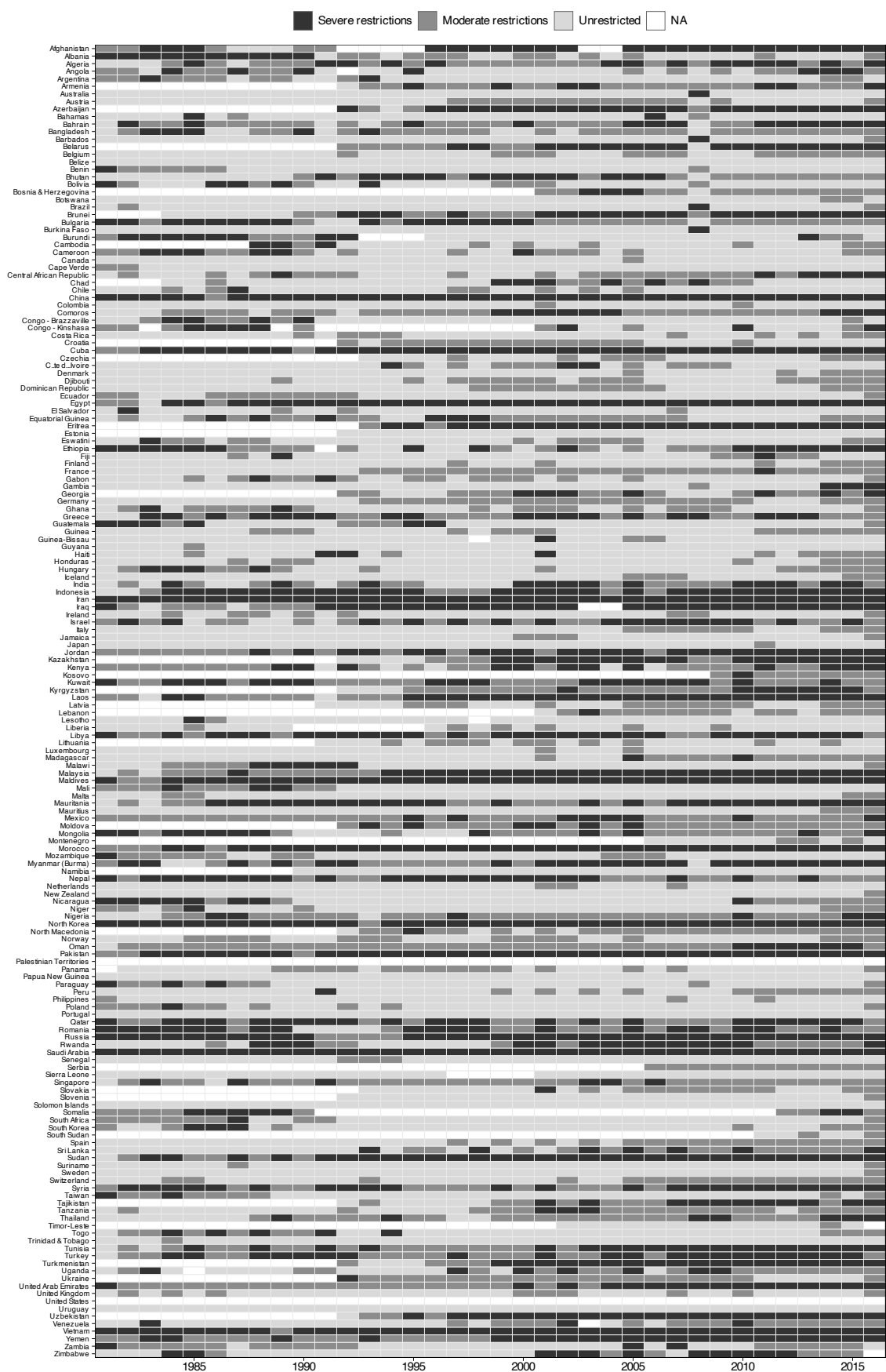


Figure 6: PANEL VIEW OF CIRIGHTS' FREEDOM OF RELIGION VARIABLE BY COUNTRY AND YEAR.

Table 6: Freedom of Religion and Religious Terrorism (H1).

|                                | <b>Organizations</b> | <b>Attacks</b>    | <b>Casualties</b>  |
|--------------------------------|----------------------|-------------------|--------------------|
|                                | (1)                  | (2)               | (3)                |
| Religious freedom: widespread  | -0.249*<br>(0.012)   | -3.579<br>(0.151) | -39.469<br>(0.179) |
| Religious freedom: moderate    | -0.232*<br>(0.017)   | -3.137<br>(0.152) | -30.747<br>(0.231) |
| Polity score                   | 0.017<br>(0.282)     | 1.073<br>(0.150)  | 10.190<br>(0.204)  |
| Log GDP per capita             | -0.016<br>(0.925)    | 3.599<br>(0.369)  | 42.686<br>(0.373)  |
| Log population                 | 0.929<br>(0.050)     | 20.779<br>(0.102) | 218.080<br>(0.120) |
| Political corruption           | 0.807<br>(0.308)     | 18.939<br>(0.105) | 201.320<br>(0.072) |
| State authority over territory | -0.061<br>(0.053)    | -1.436<br>(0.084) | -13.017<br>(0.130) |
| Ongoing armed conflict         | 0.308<br>(0.252)     | 8.413<br>(0.089)  | 81.024<br>(0.142)  |
| Religious fractionalization    | -0.626<br>(0.355)    | 2.116<br>(0.818)  | 9.519<br>(0.919)   |
| Observations                   | 4990                 | 4853              | 4853               |
| $R^2$                          | 0.759                | 0.505             | 0.325              |
| Adj. $R^2$                     | 0.749                | 0.483             | 0.296              |

Notes: TWFE estimates underlying Figure 4. Each cell reports the coefficient with the  $p$ -value in parentheses; standard errors are heteroskedasticity-robust and two-way clustered at the country and year levels. All models include country and year fixed effects, and all explanatory variables are lagged by one year. The omitted religious-freedom category is “severe restrictions”. The attacks and casualties columns exclude 1993, which is absent from the Global Terrorism Database. \* $p < 0.05$ , \*\* $p < 0.01$ , \*\*\* $p < 0.001$ .

Table 7: H1 robustness:  $\log(1 + y)$  versus Poisson (PPML).

|                                | OLS FE, $\log(1 + y)$ |                     |                     | Poisson (PPML)            |                           |                           |
|--------------------------------|-----------------------|---------------------|---------------------|---------------------------|---------------------------|---------------------------|
|                                | Orgs.                 | Attacks             | Casualties          | Orgs.                     | Attacks                   | Casualties                |
|                                | (1)                   | (2)                 | (3)                 | (4)                       | (5)                       | (6)                       |
| Religious freedom: widespread  | -0.075**<br>(0.005)   | -0.134*<br>(0.012)  | -0.215**<br>(0.009) | -0.129<br>(0.111)         | -0.081<br>(0.655)         | -0.104<br>(0.773)         |
| Religious freedom: moderate    | -0.052*<br>(0.022)    | -0.116**<br>(0.009) | -0.176**<br>(0.007) | -0.040<br>(0.527)         | -0.148<br>(0.221)         | 0.074<br>(0.713)          |
| Polity score                   | 0.004<br>(0.323)      | 0.017<br>(0.052)    | 0.024<br>(0.080)    | 0.013<br>(0.112)          | -0.010<br>(0.760)         | 0.005<br>(0.907)          |
| Log GDP per capita             | 0.018<br>(0.564)      | 0.003<br>(0.968)    | 0.045<br>(0.690)    | 0.170<br>(0.129)          | 0.445*<br>(0.044)         | 1.008*<br>(0.019)         |
| Log population                 | 0.254*<br>(0.019)     | 0.608*<br>(0.012)   | 0.911*<br>(0.014)   | 1.927***<br>( $<0.001$ )  | 2.976<br>(0.124)          | 4.327<br>(0.058)          |
| Political corruption           | 0.035<br>(0.812)      | 0.257<br>(0.330)    | 0.551<br>(0.194)    | -0.699<br>(0.310)         | 2.928<br>(0.112)          | 7.430***<br>( $<0.001$ )  |
| State authority over territory | -0.011*<br>(0.039)    | -0.026*<br>(0.048)  | -0.035<br>(0.053)   | -0.037***<br>( $<0.001$ ) | -0.079***<br>( $<0.001$ ) | -0.078***<br>( $<0.001$ ) |
| Ongoing armed conflict         | 0.030<br>(0.441)      | 0.424**<br>(0.005)  | 0.595**<br>(0.008)  | 0.020<br>(0.784)          | 1.437***<br>( $<0.001$ )  | 1.320***<br>( $<0.001$ )  |
| Religious fractionalization    | -0.456*<br>(0.029)    | -0.333<br>(0.364)   | -0.710<br>(0.217)   | -2.451<br>(0.174)         | -11.824<br>(0.446)        | 4.115<br>(0.325)          |
| Observations                   | 4990                  | 4853                | 4853                | 1732                      | 1892                      | 1869                      |

Notes: Columns (1)–(3) are two-way fixed-effects OLS estimates with the outcome transformed as  $\log(1 + y)$ ; columns (4)–(6) are Poisson pseudo-maximum-likelihood (PPML) estimates on the raw counts. The untransformed linear estimates are reported in Table 6. Each cell reports the coefficient with the  $p$ -value in parentheses; standard errors are two-way clustered at the country and year levels. All models include country and year fixed effects and one-year lags of every explanatory variable; the omitted religious-freedom category is “severe restrictions”. The  $\log(1 + y)$  columns retain the full sample, whereas PPML drops countries with a zero outcome in every year (perfect separation), reducing  $N$ . \* $p < 0.05$ , \*\* $p < 0.01$ , \*\*\* $p < 0.001$ .

Table 8: Religious Freedom and Religious Terrorism (Imputed Values for year 1993)

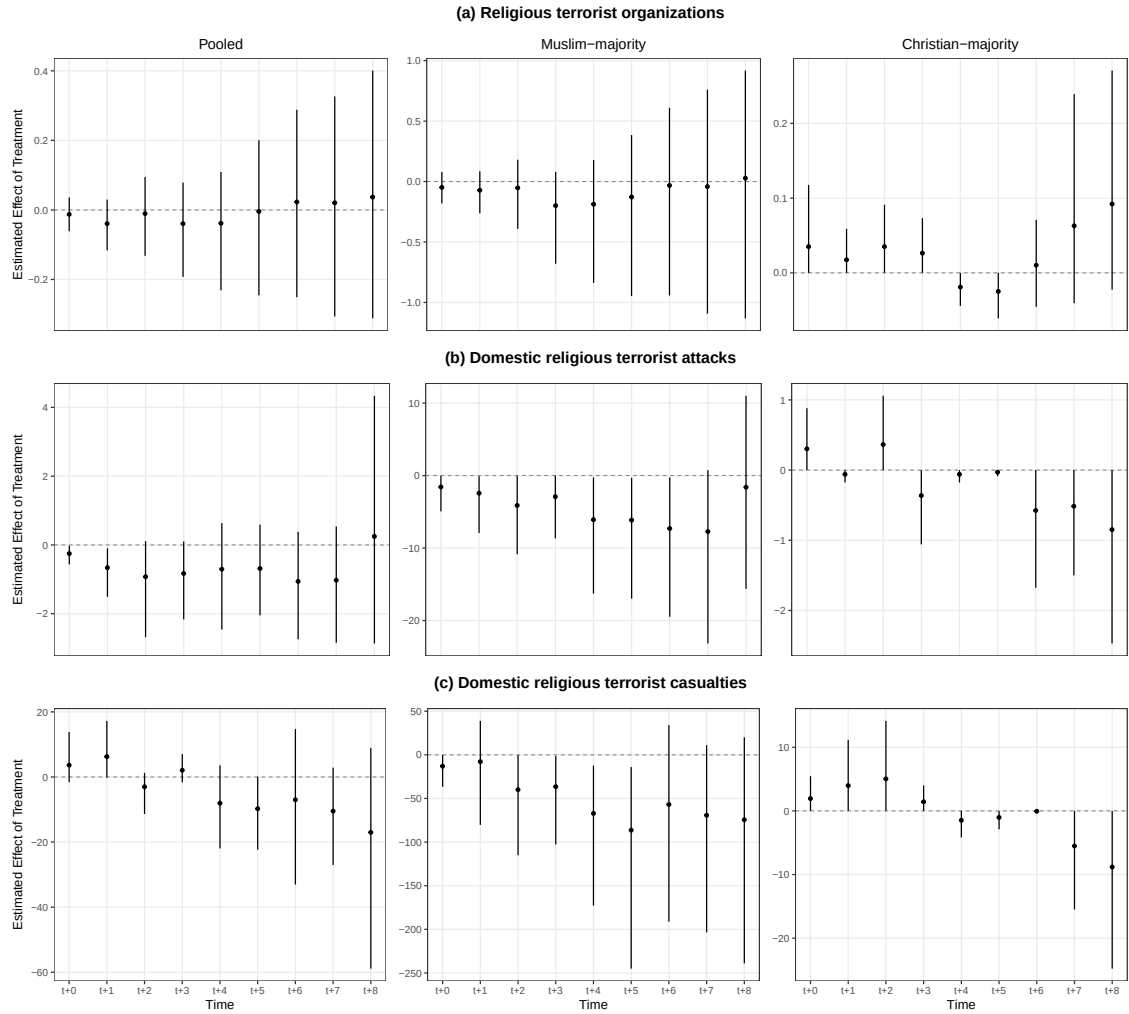
|                                | <b>Domestic</b>   |                    | <b>International</b> |                    |
|--------------------------------|-------------------|--------------------|----------------------|--------------------|
|                                | Attacks           | Casualties         | Attacks              | Casualties         |
|                                | (1)               | (2)                | (3)                  | (4)                |
| Religious freedom: widespread  | -1.120<br>(0.086) | -10.955<br>(0.125) | -2.549<br>(0.229)    | -28.053<br>(0.234) |
| Religious freedom: moderate    | -0.632<br>(0.387) | -5.254<br>(0.493)  | -2.518<br>(0.166)    | -23.950<br>(0.246) |
| Polity score                   | 0.378*<br>(0.038) | 3.048<br>(0.050)   | 0.691<br>(0.270)     | 7.199<br>(0.288)   |
| Log GDP per capita             | 1.276<br>(0.350)  | 20.562<br>(0.251)  | 2.814<br>(0.421)     | 28.651<br>(0.465)  |
| Log population                 | 7.459<br>(0.107)  | 91.447<br>(0.074)  | 13.777<br>(0.185)    | 132.807<br>(0.234) |
| Political corruption           | 11.927<br>(0.143) | 115.643<br>(0.099) | 6.594<br>(0.274)     | 82.884<br>(0.210)  |
| State authority over territory | -0.509<br>(0.094) | -2.989<br>(0.091)  | -0.877<br>(0.155)    | -9.572<br>(0.164)  |
| Ongoing armed conflict         | 6.849<br>(0.139)  | 80.547<br>(0.129)  | 1.500<br>(0.320)     | 0.076<br>(0.996)   |
| Religious fractionalization    | 2.785<br>(0.544)  | 14.234<br>(0.754)  | -1.463<br>(0.766)    | -9.795<br>(0.851)  |
| Observations                   | 4990              | 4990               | 4990                 | 4990               |
| $R^2$                          | 0.671             | 0.377              | 0.192                | 0.176              |
| Adj. $R^2$                     | 0.657             | 0.351              | 0.158                | 0.141              |

*Notes:* OLS estimates with two-way (country and year) fixed effects, included in all four models. Each cell reports the coefficient estimate with the associated  $p$ -value in parentheses below. Standard errors are heteroskedasticity-robust and two-way clustered at the country and year levels. All explanatory variables are lagged by one year. The religious-freedom variable (CIRIGHTS) is a three-category ordinal measure; the omitted baseline is countries with severe state restrictions on religious practice. Values for the calendar year 1993 are imputed by taking the average of the 1992 and 1994 values for the same country. \*  $p < 0.05$ ; \*\*  $p < 0.01$ ; \*\*\*  $p < 0.001$ .

Table 9: Religious Freedom and Religious Terrorism, by Majority Religion

|                                | Muslim-majority    |                    |                    | Christian-majority |                   |                    |
|--------------------------------|--------------------|--------------------|--------------------|--------------------|-------------------|--------------------|
|                                | Orgs.              | Attacks            | Casualties         | Orgs.              | Attacks           | Casualties         |
|                                | (1)                | (2)                | (3)                | (4)                | (5)               | (6)                |
| Religious freedom: widespread  | -0.028<br>(0.920)  | -3.618<br>(0.631)  | -46.544<br>(0.576) | -0.024<br>(0.524)  | -0.816<br>(0.076) | -1.732<br>(0.635)  |
| Religious freedom: moderate    | -0.131<br>(0.303)  | -1.825<br>(0.606)  | -30.180<br>(0.463) | 0.014<br>(0.555)   | -0.490<br>(0.128) | 7.417<br>(0.390)   |
| Polity score                   | 0.049<br>(0.298)   | 3.516<br>(0.135)   | 32.468<br>(0.210)  | 0.001<br>(0.892)   | 0.099<br>(0.132)  | 1.058<br>(0.276)   |
| Log GDP per capita             | -0.129<br>(0.790)  | 11.636<br>(0.295)  | 90.091<br>(0.504)  | -0.031<br>(0.470)  | -0.372<br>(0.381) | 0.422<br>(0.914)   |
| Log population                 | -1.012<br>(0.283)  | 20.927<br>(0.488)  | 238.627<br>(0.499) | 0.361<br>(0.097)   | 6.004*<br>(0.047) | 20.774<br>(0.147)  |
| Political corruption           | 2.546<br>(0.385)   | 72.280*<br>(0.047) | 672.217<br>(0.057) | -0.346<br>(0.230)  | -4.081<br>(0.256) | -3.857<br>(0.782)  |
| State authority over territory | -0.121*<br>(0.019) | -3.439*<br>(0.031) | -31.271<br>(0.076) | -0.005<br>(0.421)  | -0.090<br>(0.096) | -0.859*<br>(0.034) |
| Ongoing armed conflict         | 0.757<br>(0.133)   | 9.341<br>(0.084)   | 86.199<br>(0.149)  | 0.009<br>(0.823)   | 1.073*<br>(0.041) | 1.419<br>(0.863)   |
| Religious fractionalization    | 2.553<br>(0.501)   | 61.983<br>(0.235)  | 429.058<br>(0.416) | -0.409<br>(0.225)  | -2.093<br>(0.436) | -8.144<br>(0.670)  |
| Observations                   | 1275               | 1238               | 1238               | 2628               | 2557              | 2557               |
| $R^2$                          | 0.789              | 0.601              | 0.445              | 0.838              | 0.413             | 0.096              |
| Adj. $R^2$                     | 0.774              | 0.572              | 0.404              | 0.830              | 0.383             | 0.050              |

*Notes:* OLS estimates with two-way (country and year) fixed effects, included in all six models. The sample is restricted to Muslim-majority countries in columns (1)–(3) and Christian-majority countries in columns (4)–(6); a country is classified as majority if its mean population share of the relevant religion over the study period is at least 50%. Within each subsample, the dependent variable is the number of religious terrorist organizations based, the total number of attacks, and the total number of casualties (deaths + wounded), respectively. Each cell reports the coefficient with the  $p$ -value in parentheses below. Standard errors are heteroskedasticity-robust and two-way clustered at the country and year levels. All explanatory variables are lagged by one year. The omitted religious-freedom category is “severe restrictions”. Calendar year 1993 is missing from the GTD-derived outcomes (attacks and casualties). \*  $p < 0.05$ ; \*\*  $p < 0.01$ ; \*\*\*  $p < 0.001$ .



**Figure 7: IMPACT OF RELIGIOUS FREEDOMS ON RELIGIOUS TERRORISM - ALTERNATIVE SPECIFICATION.** The figure reports estimated average treatment effects on the treated (ATT) of religious freedom on the same three outcomes and across the same three subsamples as [Figure 5](#), using an alternative binarisation of the treatment. The binary treatment indicator equals one in country-years with any movement away from severe restrictions on religious practice and zero in country-years coded as having severe restrictions. Note that the corresponding main text figure instead codes only observations with country-years having widespread religious freedoms as treated. All other PanelMatch settings are held constant similar to the [Figure 5](#) values: nine separate analyses (one per (sample, outcome) cell), a three-period pre-treatment matching window, Mahalanobis refinement on the same covariates as in [Figure 4](#), each evaluated at every period of the matching window, up to five never-treated controls per treated country-year, lead estimates at t+0 through t+8, and 1,000 bootstrap iterations. Treatment reversal is allowed. Points report the estimated ATT at each lead; vertical bars give 95% bootstrap confidence intervals. The dashed horizontal line marks no effect.

Table 10: Covariate Balance for the PanelMatch Analysis

|                                              | Widespread freedom (Figure 5) |             | Any easing of restrictions (Figure 7) |             |
|----------------------------------------------|-------------------------------|-------------|---------------------------------------|-------------|
|                                              | Before                        | After       | Before                                | After       |
| <b>Panel A. Pooled sample</b>                |                               |             |                                       |             |
| Polity2 score                                | 0.22                          | 0.18        | 0.20                                  | 0.21        |
| Log GDP per capita                           | 0.12                          | 0.02        | 0.37                                  | 0.29        |
| Log population                               | 0.02                          | 0.12        | 0.09                                  | 0.13        |
| Political corruption (V-Dem)                 | 0.03                          | 0.02        | 0.04                                  | 0.04        |
| State authority over territory (V-Dem)       | 0.01                          | 0.11        | 0.12                                  | 0.16        |
| Ongoing armed conflict                       | 0.10                          | 0.17        | 0.12                                  | 0.16        |
| Religious fractionalization                  | 0.08                          | 0.08        | 0.05                                  | 0.04        |
| <i>Average, covariates</i>                   | <i>0.08</i>                   | <i>0.10</i> | <i>0.14</i>                           | <i>0.15</i> |
| Religious terrorist organizations (outcome)  | 0.38                          | 0.28        | 0.10                                  | 0.04        |
| Domestic attacks (outcome)                   | 0.26                          | 0.27        | 0.11                                  | 0.13        |
| Domestic casualties (outcome)                | 0.24                          | 0.15        | 0.08                                  | 0.15        |
| <b>Panel B. Muslim-majority countries</b>    |                               |             |                                       |             |
| Polity2 score                                | 0.07                          | 0.06        | 0.07                                  | 0.08        |
| Log GDP per capita                           | 0.11                          | 0.35        | 0.12                                  | 0.06        |
| Log population                               | 0.12                          | 0.24        | 0.06                                  | 0.04        |
| Political corruption (V-Dem)                 | 0.44                          | 0.29        | 0.29                                  | 0.30        |
| State authority over territory (V-Dem)       | 0.05                          | 0.19        | 0.56                                  | 0.50        |
| Ongoing armed conflict                       | 0.21                          | 0.35        | 0.11                                  | 0.07        |
| Religious fractionalization                  | 0.34                          | 0.39        | 0.08                                  | 0.09        |
| <i>Average, covariates</i>                   | <i>0.19</i>                   | <i>0.27</i> | <i>0.18</i>                           | <i>0.16</i> |
| Religious terrorist organizations (outcome)  | 1.31                          | 0.68        | 0.15                                  | 0.12        |
| Domestic attacks (outcome)                   | 2.31                          | 0.19        | 0.12                                  | 0.14        |
| Domestic casualties (outcome)                | 23.14                         | 0.62        | 0.09                                  | 0.12        |
| <b>Panel C. Christian-majority countries</b> |                               |             |                                       |             |
| Polity2 score                                | 0.11                          | 0.06        | 0.19                                  | 0.19        |
| Log GDP per capita                           | 0.06                          | 0.03        | 0.06                                  | 0.06        |
| Log population                               | 0.11                          | 0.13        | 0.26                                  | 0.26        |
| Political corruption (V-Dem)                 | 0.04                          | 0.03        | 0.37                                  | 0.37        |
| State authority over territory (V-Dem)       | 0.04                          | 0.09        | 0.34                                  | 0.34        |
| Ongoing armed conflict                       | 0.09                          | 0.10        | 0.41                                  | 0.41        |
| Religious fractionalization                  | 0.12                          | 0.12        | 0.39                                  | 0.39        |
| <i>Average, covariates</i>                   | <i>0.08</i>                   | <i>0.08</i> | <i>0.29</i>                           | <i>0.29</i> |
| Religious terrorist organizations (outcome)  | 0.05                          | 0.06        | 0.23                                  | 0.23        |
| Domestic attacks (outcome)                   | 0.06                          | 0.06        | 0.21                                  | 0.21        |
| Domestic casualties (outcome)                | 0.04                          | 0.05        | 0.20                                  | 0.20        |

*Notes:* The table reports standardized balance for the PanelMatch sets used in Figure 5 (widespread religious freedom) and Figure 7 (any easing of severe restrictions). Entries are mean absolute standardized differences between treated country-years and weighted matched controls, averaged across matched sets and pre-treatment periods  $t - 1$  to  $t - 3$ ; the treatment-onset period is excluded. “Before” uses equal control weights, while “After” uses the Mahalanobis refinement weights used for the ATT estimates, matching on one- to three-period lags of the seven covariates in Figure 4. Panels A–C show the pooled, Muslim-majority, and Christian-majority samples, with majority status defined by a country-level mean population share of at least 50%. The “Average, covariates” row averages the seven refinement covariates; the final rows report balance on pre-treatment outcomes. Smaller values indicate better balance, with values below roughly 0.1–0.2 standard deviations conventionally considered good. Matching settings follow Figure 5.